

A Way Can Be a Guide

A way can be a guide, but not a fixed path;

names can be given, but not permanent labels.

Nonbeing is called the beginning of heaven and earth; being is called the mother

The principle that can be enunciated is not the one that always was. The being that can be named is not the one that was at all times.

Before time there was an ineffable, unnameable being. When it was still unnameable, it conceived heaven and earth.

Words and names are not the way

They can't define the absolute

It's better that you look within

Hold your tongue and just be mute

Look within and look out too

You will not find a separation

Out there you

The way that can be told of is hardly an eternal, absolute, unvarying one; the name that can be coded and given is no absolute name.

Heaven and earth sprang from something else: the bright nameless;

the named is but the said mother that rears the ten thousand creatures of heaven and earth, each after its kind.

He that rids himself of base desire can see the secret essences;

he that didn't and reached high being, he can see outcomes.

Still

The Tao that can be told of is not the eternal Tao; The name that can be named is not the eternal name.

The Nameless is the origin of Heaven and Earth; The Named is the mother of all things.

Therefore let there always be non-being, so

of all things.

Always passionless, thereby observe the subtle;

ever intent, thereby observe the apparent.

These two come from the same source but differ in name; both are considered mysteries.

The mystery of mysteries is the gateway of marvels.

When it had thus become nameable, it gave birth to the multitude of beings.

These two acts are but one, under two different denominations.

The unique act of generation; that is the mystery of the beginning; the effects.

see appearance

Within you see origination

Look within with wonder

At emptiness and bliss

For wonder names totality

Where nothing is amiss

The space within is always there

If you can moderate desire

A place of utter emptiness

And possibility entire

the two are the same; the secret and its manifestations came from the same ground, the same mould, but anyway sound different -

they're given different names where they appear.

They can both be called the cosmic mystery, awesome deep

or rather more secret than so-called mystery.

There's the deeper mystery: the gate and doorway from which issued all secret essences, yes, all subtleties,

and the subtle mystical opening homewards.

Call it the door mystery or golden secret of all life.

we may see their subtlety, And let there always be being, so we may see their outcome.

The two are the same, But after they are produced, they have different names.

They both may be called deep and profound. Deeper and more profound, The door to all subtleties!

Therefore the sage manages affairs without action And spreads doctrines without words.

All things arise, and he does not turn away from them. He produces them but does not take possession of them.

He acts but does not rely on his own ability. He accomplishes his task but does not claim credit for it. It is precisely because he does not claim credit that his accomplishment remains with him.

Not Exalting
Cleverness

Not exalting
cleverness

causes the people not
to contend.

Not putting high
prices on hard-to-get
goods

causes the people not
to steal.

Not seeing anything
to want

causes the mind not
to be confused.

Therefore the

Not making any
special case of
cleverness, of ability,
will have the result
that people will no
longer push
themselves.

Not to prize rare
objects will have the
result that no one will
continue to steal.

To show nothing as
alluring will have the
effect of putting the
people's hearts at
rest.

Therefore the politics
of

If you love
accumulation

Gain and increase
every day

Thieves and robbers
will be waiting

Just to take it all
away

Best to

Stop looking for rare,
moral persons (hsien)
to put in power.

There will be
jealousies among
people, jealousies
and strife.

If we cease to set
store by products that
are hard to get, there
will be less outright
thieves.

If the people never
see such things as
excite desire, their
hearts can remain
placid and
undisturbed.

Therefore the wise
one rules by
emptying their hearts
[like the clown].

Do not exalt the
worthy, so that the
people shall not
compete.

Do not value rare
treasures, so that the
people shall not steal.

Do not display
objects of desire, so
that the people's
hearts shall not be
disturbed.

Therefore in the
government of the

government of sages
empties the mind and
fills the middle,

weakens the
ambition and
strengthens the
bones,

always keeping the
people innocent and
passionless.

it makes the
sophisticated not
dare to contrive;

action being without
contrivance,

nothing is disordered.

Sages consists in
emptying the minds
of men and filling
their stomachs, in
weakening their
initiative and
strengthening their
bones.

Their constant care is
to hold the people in
ignorance and
apathy. They make
things such that
clever people dare
not to act,

for there is nothing
that cannot be sorted
out through the
practice of
non-action.

be so empty-headed

That it seems you've
lost it all

You will know you're
on the way

Though others say
you're at a stall

He fills their bellies,
weakens their
brightness and
toughens their bones,

ever striving to make
the people without
knowledge.

He sees to it that if
there are any who are
bright and clever,
they dare not
interfere.

Through his non-do
actions all [such
subjection] runs well
[for some time].

sage, He keeps their
hearts vacuous, Fills
their bellies,
Weakens their
ambitions, And
strengthens their
bones,

He always causes his
people to be without
knowledge (cunning)
or desire, And the
crafty to be afraid to
act.

By acting without
action, all things will
be in order.

The Way Is
Unimpeded Harmony

The Way is
unimpeded harmony;
its potential may
never be fully
exploited.

It is as deep as the
source of all things:
it blunts the

The Principle
produces in
abundance, but
without filling itself
up.

Empty abyss, it
seems to be (is) the
ancestor (origin) of
all beings.

It is peaceful, simple,
modest, amiable.

Spilling itself out in

This nothingness is
like a well

Always giving, never
taking

And all claims to
origin

Neither wanting or
forsaking

You

Dao is like an empty
vessel that yet can be
drawn from

without ever needing
to be filled.

It's without bottom;
the very breeder of
all things in the
world.

In it all sharpness is
blunted,
all tangles untied,
all glare

Tao is empty (like a
bowl). It may be used
but its capacity is
never exhausted

It is bottomless,
perhaps the ancestor
of all things.

It blunts its
sharpness. It unties
its tangles.

edges,
resolves the
complications,
harmonizes the light,
assimilates to the
world.

Profoundly still, it
seems to be there:

I don't know whose
child it is,
before the creation of
images.

waves, it seems to
remain (it remains)
always the same.

I do not know of
whom it is the son
(where it comes
from). It seems to
have been (it was)
before the Sovereign.

know it's ever present

You find it where
you have no face

It is a wondrous
blessing

Original amazing
grace

tempered,
all turmoil smoothed.

It's like a deep pool
that never dries.

Was it too the child
of something else?

We can hardly tell.

A substanceless
image of all things
seemed to exist
before the progenitor
that we hardly know
of.

It softens its light. It
becomes one with the
dusty world.

Deep and still, it
appears to exist
forever.

I do not know whose
son it is. It seems to
have existed before
the Lord.

Heaven and Earth
Heaven and earth are
not humane;
they regard all beings
as straw dogs.
Sages are not
humane;
they see all people as
straw dogs.
The space between
heaven

Heaven and earth are
not good to the things
that they produce, but
treat them like straw
dogs.
Like heaven and
earth, the Sage is not
good for the people
he governs, but treats
them like straw dogs.
The betwixt of
heaven and earth,
seat of the Principle,
the place from where
its virtue acts, is like
a bellows, like the
bag of

This emptiness is
truly void
And infinitely
capacious
It holds whatever
comes its way
Eternally tenacious
Can you

The universe seems
without mercy, quite
ruthless;
in that wider
perspective all things
are but as ritual straw
dogs.
The wise man too is
hard as nail; to him
the people are but as
straw dogs to throw.
Yet heaven and earth
and all that lies

Heaven and Earth are
not humane. They
regard all things as
straw dogs.
The sage is not
humane. He regards
all people as straw
dogs.
How Heaven and
Earth are like a
bellows.

and earth
is like bellows and
pipes,
empty yet
inexhaustible,
producing more with
movement.
The talkative reach
their wits' end
again and again;
that is not as good as
keeping centered.

a bellows of which
heaven and earth
would be the two
boards, which
empties itself without
exhausting itself,
which moves itself
externally without
cease.
This is all that we can
understand of the
Principle and of its
action as producer.
To seek to detail it
further using words
and numbers would
be a waste of time.
Let us hold ourselves
to this grand idea.

take whatever
comes?
Though judgment
calls it bad and good
Seeing is acceptance
And nothing to be
understood

between is like a
bellows;
empty, yet yielding a
supply that hardly
fails.
Work it, and more
comes out.
Whereas the force of
words is soon spent.
It seems far better to
keep what's in the
heart.
So hold to the heart
core and a regular
mean.

While vacuous, it is
never exhausted.
When active, it
produces even more.
Much talk will of
course come to a
dead end. It is better
to keep to the centre.

The Valley Spirit
The valley spirit not
dying
is called the
mysterious female.
The opening of the
mysterious female
is called

The expansive
transcendent power
which resides in the
median space, the
virtue of the
Principle, does not
die. It is always the
same and acts the
same, without
diminution or
cessation.

Complete and full
awareness
Is like an open valley
Of endless generation
That doesn't reach
finale
It is

The valley spirit
never dies.
It's named the mystic
woman.
And the gate of the
profound woman is
the root that heaven

The spirit of the
valley never dies. It
is called the subtle
and profound female.
The gate of the subtle
and profound female
Is

the root of heaven
and earth.
Continuous, on the
brink of existence,
to put it into practice,
don't try to force it.

This virtue is the
mysterious mother of
all beings.
The doorway of this
mysterious mother is
the root of heaven
and earth, the
Principle.
Sprouting forth, she
does not expend
herself; acting, she
does not tire herself.

a simple presence
It's a nothing you can
see
You'll find it right at
center
Wherever you may
be

and earth sprang
from.
It's there within us all
the while;
draw upon it as you
will,
you can never wear it
out.

the root of Heaven
and Earth.
It is continuous, and
seems to be always
existing. Use it and
you will never wear
it out.

Heaven Is Eternal,
Earth Is Everlasting

Heaven is eternal,
earth is everlasting.

The reason they can
be eternal and
everlasting

is that they do not
foster themselves;
that is why they can

If heaven and earth
last forever,

it is because they do
not live for
themselves.

Following this
example, the Sage, in

This presence is
unlimited

Because it wasn't
ever born

And it will not be
perishing

Will never give you
cause to mourn

It truly wants for
nothing

It has no wishes of its
own

It is the one and only
Eternally

Heaven is always, the
earth, too.

How can it be?

Well, they don't live
only for themselves;
that's why they live
long.

So the wise man puts
himself last, and
finds himself in the
foremost place,

puts himself in the
background; yet
always comes to the

Heaven is eternal and
Earth everlasting.

They can be eternal
and everlasting
because they do not
exist for themselves,
And for this reason
can exist forever.

Therefore the sage
places himself in the
background

live forever.

For this reason sages
put themselves last,
and they were first;
they excluded
themselves,
and they survived.

Was it not by their
very selflessness
that they managed to
fulfill themselves?

withdrawing,
advances;

in neglecting himself,
he conserves himself.

As he does not seek
his own advantage,
everything turns to
his advantage.

alone

It holds itself in
vacancy

With no desire to
advance

Remaining in
simplicity

It merely witnesses
the dance

The seer will remain
behind

And never yearns for
leaving home

Just living in the here
and now

Prefers to stay
unknown

fore.

He keeps well fit;
looks on his body
almost as accidental,
outer, something to
be well taken care of;

still it always there,
and always remains.
He remains in the
open by it, too.

He hardly strives for
great personal ends;
his main ends seem
fulfilled.

but finds himself in
the foreground.

He puts himself
away, and yet he
always remains.

Is it not because he
has no personal
interests? This is the
reason why his
personal interests are
fulfilled.

Higher Good Is like Water

Higher good is like water:

the good in water benefits all, and does so without contention.

It rests where people dislike to be, so it is close to the Way.

Where it dwells becomes good

Transcendent goodness is like water. Water likes to do good to all beings; it does not struggle for any definite form or position, but puts itself in the lowest places that no one wants.

The seer flows like water

Lying low along the way

Nourishing whatever comes

To be held on display

The seer keeps to simple ways

And therefore is content

The highest good is like that of water.

The goodness of water is that it benefits the ten thousand creatures; yet itself hardly ever scrambles -

it seems quite content with the places that all men disdain.

It's this that can make water so near to some dao.

And if men think the ground the best place for building a

The best (man) is like water. Water is good; it benefits all things and does not compete with them. It dwells in (lowly) places that all disdain. This is why it is so near to Tao.

(The best man) in his dwelling loves the earth.

ground;
profound is the good in its heart,
benevolent the good it bestows.
Goodness in words is trustworthiness,
goodness in government is order;
goodness in work is ability,
goodness in action is timeliness.
But only by noncontention
is there nothing extreme.

By this, it is the reflection of the Principle.
From its example, those who imitate the Principle, lower themselves, sink themselves. They are benevolent, sincere, regulated, efficacious, and they conform themselves to the times.
They do not struggle for their own interest, but yield. Therefore they do not suffer and contradiction.

When joy or sorrow manifests
To give complete assent
If you can clearly be yourself
And never rise to interfere
Everyone will cherish you
And always hold you dear

house upon,
if among thoughts they value those that are profound,
if in friendship they value gentleness;
in words, truth, or sincere faithfulness,
in government, [bugbear] order;
in deeds: competence, ability, effectiveness;
in actions: timeliness and being properly timed -
In each case it's because they prefer things that hardly lead to strife, and therefore hardly go much astray or amiss.

In his heart, he loves what is profound. In his associations, he loves humanity. In his words, he loves faithfulness.
In government, he loves order. In handling affairs, he loves competence. In his activities, he loves timeliness.
It is because he does not compete that he is without reproach.

To Keep on Filling
To keep on filling
Is not as good as
stopping.
Calculated sharpness
cannot be kept for
long.
Though gold and
jewels fill their
houses,

To hold a vase filled
to the brim, without
spilling anything, is
impossible; better not
to fill it so.
To keep an
over-sharpened blade
without its edge
becoming blunt, is
impossible; better not
to sharpen it to this
extreme.
To keep a roomful of
precious stones,
without any of it
becoming
misappropriated, is
impossible; better not

Don't fill a bowl
Till it's more than full
Or sharpen a blade
Till it must go dull
Don't pile up treasure
That comes

Stretch a bow to the
full, and you'll end
up wishing you'd
stopped in time; to
hold and fill to
overflowing isn't
quite as able as to
stop in time.
Temper a sword-edge
to its very sharpest,
and you'll find it soon
grows dull.
When gold and jade
fills

To hold and fill a cup
to overflowing Is not
as good as to stop in
time.
Sharpen a sword
edge to its very
sharpest, And the
(edge) will not last
long.
When gold and jade

no one can keep
them.
When the rich upper
classes are haughty,
their legacy indicts
them.
When one's work is
accomplished
honorably,
to retire is the Way of
heaven.

to amass this
treasure.
No extreme can be
maintained for a long
time. Every height is
followed by a
decline. Likewise for
a man. Whomsoever,
having become rich
and powerful, takes
pride in himself,
prepares thereby his
own ruin.
To retire at the height
of one's own merit
and fame, that is the
way of heaven.

at great cost
Approval and riches
Are easily lost
Can you only do
What's really needed
Then stop and
withdraw
When your task is
completed?

your hall, can it be
well guarded any
more?
To be proud with
things and glory
given, could bring
ruin. Wealth and
place breed insolence
and could slowly
harm and ruin:
If your work is done,
withdraw!
That's heaven's way.
It can be opposed to
lots of ways of man.

fill your hall, You
will not be able to
keep them.
To be proud with
honour and wealth Is
to cause one's own
downfall.
withdraw as soon as
your work is done.
Such is Heaven's
Way.

Carrying Vitality and Consciousness
Carrying vitality and consciousness,
embracing them as one,
can you keep them from parting?
Concentrating energy,
making it supple,
can you be like an infant?
Purifying hidden perception,
can you make it flawless?
Loving the people,
governing the

Keep your body and spermatic soul closely united, and ensure that they do not become separated.
Apply yourself such that the air you breath in, converted into the aerial soul, animates this composite, and keeps it intact as in a new-born baby.
Withhold yourself from considerations which are too profound, in order not to wear yourself out.
As for love of the people and anxiety for the state,

Can you see as a child sees
And keep the simple vision?
See the inner oneness
With absolute precision
Hold all things in your embrace
The entire world is in your

Can you keep the unquiet physical-soul from straying, hold fast to the unity and middle, and never quit it?
Can you, when concentrating your breath, make it soft like that of an infant?
Strive after less tainted perfection, let it be aided by penetrating insight. So wipe and cleanse your vision of the mystery till all is without blur.
Can you love the people and rule the land, yet remain unknown?
Can you in opening and shutting the heavenly gates,

Can you keep the spirit and embrace the One without departing from them?
Can you concentrate your vital force and achieve the highest degree of weakness like an infant?
Can you clean and purify your profound insight so it will be spotless?
Can you love the people and govern the state without knowledge (cunning)?
Can you play the role of the female

nation,
can you be uncontrived?
As the gate of heaven opens and closes,
can you be impassive?
As understanding reaches everywhere,
can you be innocent?
Producing and developing,
producing without possessing,
doing without presuming,
growing without domineering:
this is called mysterious power.

limit yourself to non-action.
Let the gates of heaven open and close, without wishing to do something, without interfering.
Know all, be informed on everything, and for all that remain indifferent, as if you knew nothing.

care
Let things be just as they are
Extend acceptance everywhere
Let go all need to comprehend
The truth is here where all behold
Their infinite capacity
To welcome and enfold

ever play the feminine part?
Can your mind penetrate every corner of the land, but you yourself never interfere? Can you renounce the grosser mind for comprehending all inside knowledge?
Produce things and rear well,
but never lay claims to such things -
control them, never lean upon them.
Rely on some innate ability to act well.
Be a sort of master among others, just refrain from mismanaging.

in the opening and closing of the gates of Heaven?
Can you understand all and penetrate all without taking any action?
To produce things and to rear them, To produce, but not to take possession of them, To act, but not to rely on one's own ability, To lead them, but not to master them - This is called profound and secret virtue.

Thirty Spokes
Thirty spokes join at the hub:
their use for the cart is where they are not.
When the potter's wheel makes a pot, the use of the pot is precisely where

A wheel is made of thirty perceptible spokes, but it turns due to the imperceptible central axis of the hub.
Vessels are made of perceptible clay, but it is

The empty hub at center
Allows a wheel to roll
The vacancy within defines
The function of a bowl
The

We put thirty spokes together and call it a wheel; but it's on the space where there's nothing that the usefulness of the wheel depends.
We turn clay to make a vessel; but it's on the space where there's nothing that the usefulness of the vessel depends.
We pierce and cut out doors and windows to make a

Thirty spokes are united around the hub to make a wheel, But it is on its non-being that the utility of the carriage depends.
Clay is moulded to form a utensil, But it is on its non-being that

there is nothing.
When you open doors and windows for a room, it is where there is nothing that they are useful to the room.
Therefore being is for benefit,
Nonbeing is for usefulness.

their imperceptible hollow that is useful.
The imperceptible holes which make the doors and windows of a house, are its essentials.
It is the imperceptible that produces effects and results.

openness within a house
Provides location to reside
The open space that is my heart
Is where ten thousand things abide

house;
and it's on these spaces where there's nothing that the usefulness of the house depends.
Take advantage of what is, turn existing into a great advantage: just make as much as you can out of it here.
Feel free to recognise the possible usefulness of what's not yet here. Prosper by clever use of something not yet.

the utility of the utensil depends.
Doors and windows are cut out to make a room, But it is on its non-being that the utility of the room depends.
Therefore turn being into advantage, and turn non-being into utility.

Colors
Colors blind people's eyes,
Sounds deafen their ears;
flavors spoil people's palates,
the chase and the hunt
craze people's minds;
goods hard

Colours blind the eyes of man. Sound makes him deaf. Flavours exhaust his taste.
Hunting and racing, by unchaining savage passions in him, madden his heart.

Too much sound can make you deaf
Too many colors leave you blind
Can you let desire die down
And not leave

The five colours tend to confuse the eye, the five sounds of music can deafen the ear,
the five tastes all dull or spoil the palate.
Excess of hunting and chasing makes a mind go mad.
Things hard to get, keeps one on one's guard. Valuable things and products quite hard to get, can impede their owner's progress.

The five colours cause one's eyes to be blind. The five tones cause one's ears to be deaf. The five flavours cause one's palate to be spoiled.
Racing and hunting cause one's mind to be mad.

to obtain
make people's actions harmful.
Therefore sages work for the middle
and not the eyes,
leaving the latter and taking the former.

The love of rare and difficult-to-obtain objects pushes him to efforts that harm him.
Therefore the Sage looks to his stomach, and not his senses. renounces this, in order to embrace that. (He renounces what causes wear, in order to embrace what conserves).

emptiness behind?
Wanting things can drive you mad
And acquisition makes you poor
See that you are everything
And leave off wanting more

So the wise man is concerned with his tummy before his eyes. He can consider the tummy first, not the eye. That is: He disregards the world outside - "that", and he accepts, goes for and in the end grabs the supernormal powers dormant within - his daoist "this". Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other.

Goods that are hard to get injure one's activities.
For this reason the sage is concerned with the belly and not the eyes, Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other.

Favor and Disgrace
Favor and disgrace
seem alarming;
high status greatly
afflicts your person.
What are favor and
disgrace?
Favor is the lower:
get it and you're
surprised,
lose it and you're
startled.
This means favor and
disgrace are
alarming.
Why does high status
greatly afflict your
person?
The reason we have a
lot of trouble
is that

Favour, because it
can be lost, is a
source of worry.
Greatness, because it
can be ruined, is a
source of fear.
What do these two
sentences mean? The
first means that the
care required to keep
in favour, and the
fear of losing it, fill
the mind with worry.
The second points
out that ruin
generally comes from
caring too much for
one's own greatness.

Fame and shame are
equal
And so are gain and
loss
It isn't very difficult
To get this point
across
Having fame you
know that you
Are terrified to lose it
Making gain you
always fear
That others will
abuse it

Be glad for favour. Still
receive favour or
disgrace with regular
apprehension.
Be cautious not to lose
the winning sort of
favour. Lower favour
and disgrace can cause
one dismay;
We can have fears
because we have a self.
Yet what we value and
what we fear are as if
within that inner
sanctimonium self."
What does this mean:
"Favour and disgrace
can cause one dismay?
Those who receive
favour from above are
dismayed when they
receive it.
And should they lose it
they turn distraught.
What does this mean:

Be apprehensive
when receiving
favour or disgrace.
Regard great trouble
as seriously as you
regard your body.
What is meant by
being apprehensive
when receiving
favour or disgrace?
Favour is considered
inferior. Be
apprehensive when
you receive them and
also be apprehensive
when you lose them.
This is what is meant
by being
apprehensive when
receiving favour or
disgrace.

we have selves.
If we had no selves,
what troubles would
we have?
Therefore those who
embody nobility
to act for the sake of
the world
seem to be able to
draw the world to
them,
while those who
embody love
to act for the sake of
the world
seem to be worthy of
the trust of the world.

He who has no
personal ambition
does not have to fear
ruin.
He who is only
concerned about the
greatness of the
empire (and not that
of himself), he who
only desires the good
of the empire (and
not his own good), to
him the empire
should be confided
(and it would be in
good hands).

Can you see that
you're not like
Your image or
reflection?
Just see you are
totality
By looking in your
own direction
The one who is not
limited
Accepts whatever
comes or goes
And cares for
everything around
On opening and close

we fear are as if within
our serious self?"
Regard great trouble as
seriously as you regard
the body. One reason
that we suffer hurt is that
we have bodies.
When we don't regard
that gross body as [most
important aspect of self,
what have we to fear?
[Lao tse.]
And so, the one who
values his experienced
world as part of his
exploring inner self, can
then be entrusted with
rule of something.
he who loves the all as
an aspect of his sensing
self -
The all can then be
entrusted to his care.

The reason why I
have great trouble is
that I have a body
(and am attached to
it). If I have no body,
What trouble could I
have?
Therefore he who
values the world as
his body may be
entrusted with the
empire. He who
loves the world as his
body may be
entrusted with the
empire.

When You Look at It
You Don't See It

What you don't see
when you look

is called the
unobtrusive.

What you don't hear
when you listen

is called the rarefied.

What you don't get
when you grasp

is called the subtle.

These three cannot
be completely
fathomed,

so they merge into
one;

above is not bright,
below is not dark.

Looking, one does
not see it, for it is
invisible. Listening,
one does not hear it,
for it is silent.

Touching, one does
not feel it, for it is
impalpable.

These three attributes
must not be
separated, for they
designate one and the
same being.

This being, the
Principle, is not light
above and dark
below, as are opaque
material bodies. Like
a slender thread, it
unwinds itself (as
continuous existence
and action).

When you look, it
isn't there

Listen and you
cannot hear it

It seems to be beyond
your reach

Because you are so
near it

This single source of
everything

Appears to be an
empty image

Though it cannot be
understood

You can

Look at it, it can't be
seen,

is called the invisible.

Listen to it, it can't be
heard,

is called the inaudible.

Grasp at it, it can't be
touched,

is called the fine
formless..

These three elude all
solid inquiries

And merge and
become one.

Its rising brings no
light;

its sinking, no
darkness.

Unceasing,
continuous,
it can't be defined,

We look at it and do
not see it; Its name is
The Invisible. We
listen to it and do not
hear it; Its name is
The Inaudible. We
touch it and do not
find it; Its name is
The Subtle
(formless).

These three cannot
be further inquired
into, And hence
merge into one.

Going up high, it is
not bright, and
coming down low, it
is not dark.

again to nothing.

This is called the
stateless state,
the image of no
thing;

this is called mental
abstraction.

When you face it you
do not see its head,
when you follow it
you do not see its
back.

Hold the ancient
Way

so as to direct present
existence:

only when you can
know the ancient

can this be called the
basic cycle of the
Way.

It has no name of its
own. It goes back as
far as the time when
there were no other
beings but itself.

It has no parts; from
in front one sees no
head, from behind no
rear.

It is this primordial
Principle that has
ruled, and rules, all
beings right up to the
present. Everything
that has been, or is,
since the ancient
origin, is from the
unwinding of the
Principle.

see its naked visage

Follow it to
nothingness

Approach it where
you have no face

From nowhere to
infinity

This vacant image
leaves no trace

From never to
eternity

This naked face is
what you are

An empty, vacant,
open door

Forevermore ajar

the way back to where
there's nothing.

It's called shape free
from shapes;

forms without form;

the image of
nothingness.

That's why it's called
the elusive;

Go towards them, and
you can see no
physical front;

go after them, and you
see no rear.

Hold on to the dao of
old to master the
things of the present.

Master what once
was, at the start,

It's the essence of
rarefied,
pearl-stringed dao.

Infinite and
boundless, it cannot
be given any name; It
reverts to
nothingness.

This is called shape
without shape, Form
without objects. It is
the Vague and
Elusive. Meet it and
you will not see its
head. Follow it and
you will not see its
back.

Hold on to the Tao of
old in order to master
the things of the
present. From this
one may know the
primeval beginning
(of the universe).
This is called the
bond of Tao.

Skilled Warriors of Old
Skilled warriors of old were subtle,
mysteriously powerful,
so deep they were unknowable.
just because they are unknowable,
I will try to describe them.
Their wariness was as that of one crossing a river in winter,
their caution was as that of one in fear of all around;
their gravity was as that of a guest,
their relaxation was as that of

The ancient Sages were subtle, abstract, profound, in a way that cannot be expressed in words.
Therefore I am going to use illustrative comparisons in order to make myself as clearly understood as possible. They were circumspect like one who crosses an ice-covered river; prudent like one who knows that his neighbours have their eyes on him; reserved like a guest in front of his host.
They were indifferent like melting ice (which is neither one thing nor the other). They were unsophisticated like a tree trunk (the rough bark of which conceals the excellent heartwood). They were empty like a valley (with reference to the mountain that form it).

Those of old who knew the way
To origin and source within
Have seen the place where wholeness
And infinity begin
Alert as one on a frozen stream
Or one who watches for the foe
Deferential as a guest
And

The best rulers of old had fine natures, mysterious, too deep, they could not be understood.
And because such men could not be fully grasped at once, they appeared to be cautious, like wading a stream in winter;
at a loss, like one fearing and having to deal with danger on every side;
reserved, like one who pays a visit;
pliant and yielding, as ice when it begins to melt;
genuine, like a piece of raw wood;
open-minded like a valley;

Of old those who were the best rulers were subtly mysterious and profoundly penetrating; Too deep to comprehend.
And because they cannot be comprehended, I can only describe them arbitrarily: Cautious, like crossing a frozen stream in the winter, Being at a loss, like one fearing danger on all sides, Reserved, like one visiting,
Supple and pliant, like ice about to melt.

ice at the melting point.
Simple as uncarved wood,
open as the valleys,
they were inscrutable as murky water.
Who can, in turbidity, use the gradual clarification of stillness?
Who can, long at rest, use the gradual enlivening of movement?
Those who preserve this Way do not want fullness.
Just because of not wanting fullness,

They were accommodating like muddy water, (they, the clear water, not repelling the mud, not refusing to live in contact with the common people, not forming a separate group).
(To seek purity and peace by separating from the world is to overdo things. They can be found in the world). Purity is to be found in the trouble (of this world) through (interior) calm, on condition that one does not let the impurity of the world affect oneself. Peace is to be found in the movement (of this world) by one who knows how to take part in this movement, and who is not exasperated through desiring that is should be stopped.
He who keeps to this rule of not being consumed by sterile desires arising from his own fancy, will live willingly in obscurity, and will not aspire to renew the world.

generous as melting snow
Plain as an uncarved block of wood
Expansive as a vale
Transparent just like water
Whose clarity will never fail
Can you keep yourself so still
That muddy water clears?
And wait until right action
Spontaneously appears?

Find repose in a muddy world by lying still; be gradually clear through tranquillity. You can assume such murkiness, to become in the end still and clear. And maintain your calm long in between.
So make yourself inert, to get in the end full of life and stir.
By such activity come back to life.
Who hugs this dao doesn't want to fill himself to overflowing.
It's just because he guards against being over-full, there's no overflowing, and next he is like a garment that endures all, beyond wearing out and renewal.

Genuine, like a piece of uncarved wood, Open and broad, like a valley, Merged and undifferentiated, like muddy water.
Who can make muddy water gradually clear through tranquillity? Who can make the still gradually come to life through activity?
He who embraces this Tao does not want to fill himself to overflowing. It is precisely because there is no overflowing that he is beyond wearing out and renewal.

Attain the Climax of Emptiness

Attain the climax of emptiness,

preserve the utmost quiet:

as myriad things act in concert,

I thereby observe the return.

Things flourish,

then each returns to its root.

Returning to the root is called stillness:

stillness is called return to Life,

return to Life is called

He who has reached the maximum of emptiness (of indifference) will be firmly fixed in peace.

Innumerable beings come out (from non-being), and I see them return there. They spring forth, then they all return to their root.

To return to one's root, is to enter into the state of rest. From this rest they emerge for a new destiny, and so it goes on, continually, without end.

See that you are emptiness

Always quiet and at peace

You're in the place where all begins

The space where all things cease

All things arise and have their day

And then

Attain complete humility towards the void;

hold firm to the basis of quietude.

The myriad things take shape and rise to activity,

Now, I watch them fall, worked on,

back to their repose and roots

like plants that flourish

but return to the soil and root they grew from.

To return to the root is basic repose;

it's quiet and returning to some destiny.

To submit to a destiny is to find the eternal shelter, the always-so, or the eternal dao.

To know the eternal always-so is to

Attain complete vacuity. Maintain steadfast quietude.

All things come into being, And I see thereby their return. All things flourish, But each one returns to its root.

This return to its root means tranquillity. It is called returning to its destiny. To return to destiny is called the eternal (Tao). To know the eternal is called enlightenment.

the constant;

knowing the constant is called enlightenment.

Acts at random, in ignorance of the constant, bode ill.

Knowing the constant gives perspective;

this perspective is impartial.

Impartiality is the highest nobility;

the highest nobility is divine,

and the divine is the Way.

This Way is everlasting,

To recognize this law of immutable continuity (of the two states of life and death), is wisdom. To ignore it, is foolish. Those ignorant of this law cause misfortune (through their untimely interference in things).

He who knows that this law weighs heavily on beings, is just (treats all beings according to their nature, with equity), like a King, like Heaven, like the Principle.

In consequence he lasts until the end of his days, not having made himself any enemies.

go back to the single source

Returning to serenity

With no regret and no remorse

When you see the source within

You only give assent

You see you're everlasting

And eternally omnificent

be somewhat illumined.

not to know it courts disaster.

He who knows the eternal shelter has room in him for nearly everything - he is wide as tolerant.

Being much including, there's little prejudice;

to be without blunt prejudice is kingly;

to be kingly is to be well in accord with nature; it's to be of heaven.

To be of heaven in unison with an undaunted nature is to be in dao;

This dao is forever, and he that owns it, is hardly destroyed, even though his body ceases.

Not to know the eternal is to act blindly to result in disaster.

He who knows the eternal is all-embracing. Being all-embracing, he is impartial. Being impartial, he is kingly (universal). Being kingly, he is one with Nature. Being one with Nature, he is in accord with Tao.

Being in accord with Tao, he is everlasting And is free from danger throughout his lifetime.

Very Great Leaders
Very great leaders in
their domains
are only known to
exist.
Those next best are
beloved and praised.
The lesser are feared
and despised.
Therefore when faith

In the early days
(when, in human
affairs, everything
still conformed to the
action of the
Principle), subjects
scarcely knew that
they had a prince (so
discreet was the
action of the latter).
After this the people
loved and flattered
their prince (because
of his good deeds),
but later on, they
feared him (because
of his laws), and
scorned him (because
of his unjust —

It's best if you are
barely known
The lesser state is
being praised
Worse is being hated
Just stay empty and
amazed
Only

Of the best the
people hardly ever
know they exist;
The next best they
flock to and praise
for nothing.
The next they shrink
from;
the next get reviled.
"Not believing
people you turn them
into liars" -
such bosses don't
command the
people's faith.
They lose faith in

The best (rulers) are
those whose
existence is (merely)
known by the people.
The next best are
those who are loved
and praised. The next
are those who are
feared. And the next
are those who are
despised.
It is only

is insufficient
and there is disbelief,
it is from the high
value placed on
words.
Works are
accomplished, tasks
are completed,
and ordinary folk all
say
they are acting
spontaneously.

acts).
They became
disloyal, though
having been treated
disloyally. They lost
confidence in him
though receiving
only good words
which were never put
into effect.
How delicate was the
touch of ancient
rulers. When
everything prospered
under their
administration, the
people believed they
had done everything
themselves, of their
own free will.

do what must be
done
And see you are the
one alone
When you finish all
will say
We did this on our
own

them and take to
oaths!
The wise man is a
clever ruler; he
values his words
highly.
It's so hard to get a
single word from at
any price that when
his task is finished, a
work well done,
everyone says,
"It happened by
itself, and we did it."

when one does not
have enough faith in
others that others will
have no faith in him.
(The great rulers)
value their words
highly. They
accomplish their
task; they complete
their work.
Nevertheless their
people say that they
simply follow
Nature.

When the Great Way
Is Deserted

When the Great Way
is deserted,
then there is
humanitarian duty.

When intelligence
comes forth,
there is

When action
conforming to the
Principle dwindles,
(when men cease to
act with spontaneous
goodness and
fairness), artificial
principles of
goodness and
fairness, prudence
and wisdom (are
invented).

These artificial
principles soon
degenerate into
politics.

When

Goodness and
compliance

Came when people
lost the

When the great dao
declined,
jen and i arose,
humanity and
righteousness."

Next, when
brightness and
know-how came in
vogue,
the great pretence
fully started.

When the six family

When the great Tao
declined, The
doctrine of humanity
and righteousness
arose.

When knowledge and
wisdom appeared,
There emerged great
hypocrisy.

When the six family
relationships are not

great fabrication.

When relations are
discordant,
then there is family
love.

When the national
polity
is benighted and
confused,
then there are loyal
ministers.

parents no longer live
in natural harmony,
they try to make up
for this deficit by
inventing artificial
principles of filial
piety and paternal
affection.

When states had
fallen into disarray,
they invented the
loyal minister
stereotype.

way

Spontaneity declined

Hypocrisy was here
to stay

relationships are not
in harmony

There's open talk of
kind parents" dutiful
sons" and deep love
to children.

A confused country
enmeshed in disorder
praises ministers in
chaos and misrule.

in harmony, There
will be the advocacy
of filial piety and
deep love to children.

When a country is in
disorder, There will
be the praise of loyal
ministers.

Eliminate Sagacity,
Abandon Knowledge

Eliminate sagacity,
abandon knowledge,
and the people
benefit a
hundredfold.

Eliminate
humanitarianism,
abandon duty,
and the people return
to familial love.

Eliminate craft,
abandon profit,

Reject (artificial,
conventional,
political) wisdom
and prudence, (in
order to return to
primal natural
uprightness). and the
people will be a
hundred times
happier.

Reject (artificial,
conventional)
goodness and
fairness, (filial and
fraternal piety), and
the people will come
back (for their
well-being, to natural
goodness and

Banish learned
discourse

And everyone will be
content

Eliminate propriety

Increase
astonishment

Stay away from fraud
and swindle

Everyone is bound to
gain

You really have it all
you

Banish wisdom,
discard knowledge,
Then the people will
benefit a hundred
times.

Banish human love,
just dump righteous,
moral justice,
and then the people
will be dutiful and
recover deep love of
their kin.

Banish cunning and
skill, dispel profit;
dismiss utility,"
then thieves and
robbers will
disappear.

These three things
are not enough;
externals

Abandon sageliness
and discard wisdom;
Then the people will
benefit a
hundredfold.

Abandon humanity
and discard
righteousness; Then
the people will return
to filial piety and
deep love.

Abandon skill and
discard profit; Then

and theft will no
longer exist.

These three become
insufficient
when used for
embellishment
causing there to be
attachments.

See the basic,
embrace the
unspoiled
lessen selfishness,
diminish desire.

fairness), to
spontaneous filial
and paternal piety.

Reject art and gain,
and evildoers will
disappear. (With the
primordial
simplicity, they will
return to primordial
honesty).

Renounce these three
artificial categories,
for the artificial is
good-for-nothing.

Be attached to
simplicity and
naturalness. Have
few personal
interests, and few
desires.

know

There is no basis to
complain

Can you see your
empty core?

It isn't missing, gone
or hidden

Just let go of
neediness

And it will come
unbidden

are somehow
decorations,
purpose's not
enough; they tend to
rob life and make it
too little
complicated.

Therefore let people
hold well on to
keeping accessories;
keeping simplicity to
look at.

Go on and shield
their internal soul's
nature

as some ritual, raw
block to hold,
their private, secret
means and foster less
ardent desires.

there will be no
thieves or robbers.

However, these three
things are ornaments
(wen) and are not
adequate.

Therefore let people
hold on to these:
Manifest plainness,
Embrace simplicity,
Reduce selfishness,
Have few desires.

Chapter 20
Thomas Cleary

Detach from Learning and
You Have No Worries

Detach from learning and
you have no worries.

How far apart are yes and
yeah?

How far apart are good and
bad?

The things people fear
cannot but be feared.

Wild indeed the
uncentered!

Most people celebrate
as if they were barbecuing a
slaughtered cow,

or taking in the springtime
vistas;

I alone am aloof,

showing no sign,

like an infant that doesn't
yet smile

riding buoyantly

as if with nowhere to go.

Most

Chapter 20
Derek Bryce

Give up learning, and you
will be free from all your
worries. What is the
difference between yes and
no (about which the
rhetoricians have so much
to say)? What is the
difference between good
and evil (on which the
critics never agree)? (These
are futilities that prevent the
mind from being free. Now
freedom of mind is
necessary to enter into
relation with the Principle).

Without doubt, among the
things which common
people fear, there are things
that should be feared; but
not as they do, with a mind
so troubled that they lose
their mental equilibrium.

Chapter 20
Jim Claffelder

You need not give a
yes or no

Such distinctions
matter little

Keep your vision
open

And be at center
noncommittal

See that it's
ridiculous

To seek success and
fear to fail

To ever want what
others want

To think you always
must prevail

Other people look so
bright

I am dark and

Chapter 20
Tormond Byrn

Abandon learning and there
will be no sorrow.

Between Yes, sir," and Of
course not", how much
difference is there?

Between good" and bad",
how much difference is
there?

That which men fear is
indeed to be feared;

alas confused, and the end
isn't yet.

All men are wreathed in
smiles, ever merry-making,

as if feasting after the great
sacrifice, like ascending a
tower in spring.

I alone am inert, like a child
that has not yet given sign;

Like a new-born child that
can't smile yet.

I seem to be without a home,
droop and drift, as though I
belonged nowhere,
completely unattached.

All men have enough and to
spare;

Chapter 20
Wing-Tsit Chan

Abandon learning and
there will be no sorrow.

How much difference
is there between "Yes,
sir," and "Of course
not"? How much
difference is there
between "good" and
"evil"?

What people dread, do
not fail to dread. But,
alas, how confused, and
the end is not yet.

The multitude are
merry, as though
feasting on a day of
sacrifice. Or like
ascending a tower in
the springtime. I alone
am inert, showing no
sign (of desires), Like
an infant that has not
yet smiled.

Wearied, indeed, I
seem to be without a —

people have too much;

I alone seem to be missing
something.

Mine is indeed the mind of
an ignoramus

in its unadulterated
simplicity.

Ordinary people try to
shine;

I alone seem to be dark.

Ordinary people try to be
on the alert;

I alone am unobtrusive,
calm as the ocean depths,
buoyant as if anchored
nowhere.

Most people have ways and
means;

I alone am unsophisticated
and simple.

I alone am different from
people

in that I value seeking food
from the mother.

I (the Sage) seem to be
colourless and undefined;
neutral as a new-born child
that has not yet experienced
any emotion; without
design or aim.

The common people
abound (in varied
knowledge), but I am poor
(having rid myself of all
uselessness) and seem
ignorant, so much have I
purified myself.

They seem full of light, I
seem dull. They seek and
scrutinize, I remain
concentrated in myself.
Indeterminate, like the
immensity of the oceans, I
float without stopping.

They are full of talent,
whereas I seem limited and
uncultured. I differ thus
from the common people,
because I venerate and
imitate the universal
nourishing mother, the
Principle.

void and null

Others are so very
sharp

While I alone am dull

Others are so
purposeful

Only I don't
understand

Aimless, drifting,
weak and dumb

Uninteresting and
bland

I see I'm different
from the rest

For I take in what's
plainly shown

And I take my
sustenance

Only from the great
unknown

one left out.

Mine is indeed the mind of a
very idiot, my heart must be
that of a fool,

dull as I seem - muddled,
nebulous!

The world is full of knowing
people that shine;

I alone am dull, confused.

I seem to be in the dark.

They look lively and
clear-cut self-assured;

I appear alone, depressed, or
patient as the sea,

blown adrift, seemingly
aimless, never brought to a
stop.

All men can be put to some
use; as worldlings have a
purpose.

I alone am intractable and
boorish, appearing rustic,
stubborn and uncouth,
differing from most people,

But I differ most from others
in that I prize no sustenance
that doesn't come from the
breast of mama mia.

home.

The multitude all
possess more than
enough. I alone seem to
have lost all. Mine is
indeed the mind of an
ignorant man,
Indiscriminate and
dull!

Common folks are
indeed brilliant; I alone
seem to be in the dark.

Common folks see
differences and are
clear-cut; I alone make
no distinctions. I seem
drifting as the sea; Like
the wind blowing
about, seemingly
without destination.

The Countenance of Great Virtue

For the countenance of great virtue, only the Way is to be followed.

As a thing, the Way is abstract and elusive:

elusive and abstract, there are images in it; abstract and elusive, there is something

All of the beings which play a role, in the great manifestation of the cosmic theater, have come from the Principle, through its virtue (its unwinding).

The Principle is indistinct and indeterminate, mysterious and obscure. In its indistinction and indetermination there are types, a multitude of beings.

Seeming utter emptiness

Quite impossible to trace

Yet it contains all images

Within its wide embrace

Appearing total darkness

Yet you see that it is right

To

The marks of great virtue follow alone from the (one) dao.

What's called one dao seems impalpable and vague, not to be measured at all.

Dao is an elusive, virtually incommensurable form, but eluding, elusive it contains sub-forms.

The all-embracing quality of the great virtue follows alone from the Tao.

The thing that is called Tao is eluding and vague. Vague and eluding, there is in it the form. Eluding and vague, in it are things. Deep and obscure, in it is the essence.

there.

Recondite, hidden, it has vitality therein: that vitality is very real; it has truth therein.

From ancient times to now, its name is the undeparting; thereby are seen all beauties.

How do I know all beauties are thus?

By this.

In its mystery and obscurity there is an essence which is reality.

From ancient times until the present, its name (its being) has stayed the same, all beings have come from it.

How do I know that it was the origin of all beings? ... (By objective observation of the universe, which reveals that contingencies must have come from the absolute).

stay with its obscurity

The only origin of light

This ever present openness

At center and within

Can be seen just anytime

So look and look again

is the life-force.

The life-force is real and to be trusted.

It's true, and can be set to operate. and latent in it are evidences.

From the days of old till now

its chunks havent departed or ceased,

By its chunks we can view some origin of all descended units.

How do I know a father of a thing? How to know how some origin of a manifestation is formed?

The essence is very real; in it are evidences.

From the time of old until now, its name (manifestations) ever remains. By which we may see the beginning of all things.

How do I know that the beginning of all things are so? Through this (Tao).

Be Tactful and You
Remain Whole

Be tactful and you
remain whole;

bend and you remain
straight.

The hollow is filled,
the old is renewed.

Economy is gain,
excess is confusion.

Therefore sages
embrace unity
as a model for the
world.

Not seeing
themselves,
they are therefore
clear.

Not asserting
themselves,
they are therefore

In the old days they
said, the incomplete
shall be made whole,
the bent shall be
straightened, the
empty shall be filled,
the worn shall be
renewed. Simplicity
makes for success,
multiplicity leads one
astray.

Therefore the Sage
who holds himself to
unity, is the model
for the empire, (for
the world, the ideal
man).

He shines, because
he does not show off.

Overcome by giving
up

See that you are
really nil

Look into your
emptiness

If you want to have
your fill

Be satisfied with
little

Just content with
what you need

If you are always
wanting more

You surely are
consumed by greed

Abide in your
simplicity

Though you are not
on

"To remain whole,
yield somewhat or
seem curved and bent
if you may."

To become straight,
let yourself look
bent.

To become full, seem
hollow.

Seem tattered now,
that you can be
renewed.

Those that have little,
can get more,

To have plenty is to
be confused..

Therefore the wise
man clasps the
primal unity, testing
by it everything
under heaven by
himself - it.

To yield is to be
preserved whole. To
be bent is to become
straight. To be empty
is to be full. To be
worn out is to be
renewed. To have
little is to possess. To
have plenty is to be
perplexed.

Therefore the sage
embraces the One
And becomes the
model of the world.

He does not justify
himself; therefore he
becomes prominent.

outstanding.

Not congratulating
themselves,
they are therefore
meritorious.

Not taking pride in
themselves,
they last long.

It is just because they
do not contend
that no one in the
world can contend
with them.

Is it empty talk, the
old saying
that tact keeps you
whole?

When truthfulness is
complete,
it still resorts to this.

He imposes himself
because he does not
claim to be right.
One finds merit in
him, because he does
not brag. He
increases constantly
because he does not
push himself.

As he does not
oppose himself to
anyone, no one is
opposed to him.

The axioms from the
old days cited above,
are they not full of
sense? Yes, towards
him who is perfect,
(who does nothing to
attract to himself), all
run spontaneously.

display

See all things are
shining bright

In marvelous array

If you do not boast or
brag

Everyone will hold
you high

If you do not argue
You will prevail
thereby

Only see you are
complete

And all things have
come to you

Overcome by giving
up

All except your inner
view

is therefore luminous
and clear.

He doesn't define
himself, therefore he
is distinct.

He doesn't boast,
therefore people give
him credit: he
succeeds by that.

He's never outright
proud of his work,
and therefore it
endures.

Because he doesn't
contend, none in the
world can contend
with him.

So the old saying To
remain whole, seem
twisted!" was no idle
word;

He does not boast of
himself; therefore he
is given credit. He
does not brag;
therefore he can
endure for long.

It is precisely
because he does not
compete that the
world cannot
compete with him.

Is the ancient saying,
"To yield is to be
preserved whole,"
empty words? Truly
he will be preserved
and (prominence and
credit) will come to
him.

To Speak Rarely Is Natural

To speak rarely is natural.

That is why a gusty wind doesn't last the morning,

a downpour of rain doesn't last the day.

Who does this? Heaven and earth.

If even heaven and earth cannot go on forever,

how much less can human beings!

Therefore those who follow the Way assimilate

To talk little, to act only without effort, that is the formula. A gusty wind does not blow all morning, torrential rain does not last all day.

And yet these effects are produced by heaven and earth, (the most powerful agents of all. But these are exaggerated, forced effects, that is why they cannot be sustained). If heaven and earth cannot sustain a forced action, how much less is man able to do so?

He who conforms himself to the Principle, conforms

Say your piece and then be still

Like nature in a storm

That rains and blows and ceases

And sees the sun reborn

Open to the inward view

You are at one with all existence

To be always talking goes against nature.

For the same reason a good whirlwind never lasts the whole morning, nor a swell rainstorm the whole day.

The wind and rain emerge from nature. And if even nature can't blow, last or pour for long, how much less should man-given tenets?

So, he who takes to or follows (one) dao, becomes merged with (this) dao. Or if one uses dao as one's instrument, the results will be like dao.

Who follows virtue, is soaked by it.

If one uses the power" as one's instrument, the results will be like the —

Nature says few words. For the same reason a whirlwind does not last a whole morning. Nor does a rainstorm last a whole day.

What causes them? It is Heaven and Earth (Nature). If even Heaven and Earth cannot make them last long, How much less can man?

Therefore he who follows Tao is identified with Tao. He who follows virtue is identified with virtue. He who abandons (Tao) is identified with the abandonment (of Tao).

to the Way;
the virtuous assimilate to virtue,
those who have lost assimilate to loss.

Those who assimilate to the Way are happy to gain it,

those who assimilate to virtue too are happy to gain it,

and those who assimilate to loss are also happy to gain it.

When trust is insufficient, there is distrust.

his principles to this Principle, his actions to the action of this Principle, his non-action to the non-action of this Principle.

Thus his principles, his actions, his non-action, (speculations, interventions, abstentions), always give him the contentment of success, (for, whether he succeeds or not, the Principle evolves, and therefore he is content).

There's nothing blocking up the way
Or putting up resistance

If you're at home with nothingness

And simply trust what comes about

You'll find that all is in its place

Without a question or a doubt

power.

If one uses what's the reverse of the power", the results will be the reverse of the power".

Who is dao identified, could be glad as well. For to those who have conformed themselves to dao, dao readily lends its power.

To those who have conformed themselves to the power, the power readily lends more power.

While to those who conform themselves to inefficacy, inefficacy readily lends its ineffectiveness.

Who has not enough faith will not be able to get faith. Or:

He who is identified with Tao - Tao is also happy to have him.

He who is identified with virtue - virtue is also happy to have him. And he who is identified with the abandonment (of Tao) - the abandonment (of Tao) is also happy to abandon him.

Those who lack trust will not be trusted. It is only when one does not have enough faith in others that others will have no faith in him.

Those on Tiptoe
Don't Stand Up

Those on tiptoe don't stand up,
those who take long strides don't walk;
those who see themselves are not perceptive,
those who assert themselves are not illustrious;
those

By dint of holding oneself on tiptoe, one loses one's balance.
By trying to take too great a stride, one does not go forward.

By making a show of oneself, one loses one's reputation.
Through imposing oneself, one loses one's influence.

Through boasting about oneself, one becomes discredited.

Who stands on tiptoe topples

Who runs ahead soon loses speed

Who goes on show is hidden

Who pushes far gives up

Who stands on tiptoe, doesn't stand steady;

He who takes the longest strides, doesn't walk.."

He who does his own looking sees little, and he who shows or reveals himself is hardly luminous

He who justifies and defines himself isn't subsequently distinct.

He who boasts of what he will do succeeds in nothing;

Who brags doesn't endure for long.

He who stands on tiptoe is not steady.
He who strides forward does not go.

He who shows himself is not luminous. He who justifies himself is not prominent.

He who boasts of himself is not given credit.

who glorify themselves have no merit,
those who are proud of themselves do not last.

On the Way, these are called overconsumption and excess activity.

Some people disdain them,
so those with the Way abstain.

Through pushing oneself, one ceases to be augmented.

In the light of the Principle all these ways of acting are odious, distasteful. They are superfluous excesses. They are like a pain in the stomach, a tumour in the body. He who has principles (in conformity with the Principle), does not act like this.

the lead

Don't depart from what is given

The ever present here and now

Don't overreach and don't oppose

Invite, admire and allow

Who is proud of his work, achieves nothing well lasting.

Such people are like remnants of food and tumours of action from the dao point of view. Good braggarts could be dregs. So it's said

"Pass round superfluous dishes to those that have already had enough,

Such things of disgust all are likely to detest and reject in disgust."

So the man of dao spurns them. The man that has dao doesn't stay to brag and show off.

He who brags does not endure for long.

From the point of view of Tao, these are like remnants of food and tumours of action, Which all creatures detest. Therefore those who possess Tao turn away from them.

Something
Undifferentiated

Something
undifferentiated was
born before heaven and
earth;

still and silent, standing
alone and unchanging,
going through cycles
unending,

able to be mother to the
world.

I do not know its name;
I label it the Way.

Imposing on it a name,
I call it Great.

Greatness means

There is a being, of
unknown origin,
which existed before
heaven and earth;
imperceptible and
undefined, unique and
immutable,
omnipresent, the
mother of everything
there is.

I do not know it by its
own name. I designate
it by the word
Principle. If it were
necessary to name it,
one would call it the
Great,

great going forth,
great distance, great
return.

(The principle of the
great cyclic evolution
of the cosmos, of the
becoming and ending
of all —

Before creation did
occur

This blessed
emptiness was here

Alone forever and at
peace

The source of all that
does appear

Eternally unchanging

Forever lacking limit

This void is all
potential

The everlasting
ultimate

It

Before heaven and earth
here was something
nebulous, formless yet
complete;

without sound, without
substance, isolated, free
from all form;

standing alone and
depending on nothing,
unchanging, operating
everywhere, all pervading,
revolving and without fail.

One can think of it as the
mother of all

I don't know its true name. I
call it dao.

"Way" is the by-name.

If forced to give it a name I
can call it great (ta) .

Now such greatness implies
reaching out in space, and
also means functioning
everywhere, or passing on;

Space-yielding or
functioning everywhere
signifies far-reaching. And
passing on means going far
away,

There was something
undifferentiated and
yet complete, Which
existed before heaven
and earth. Soundless
and formless, it
depends on nothing
and does not change.
It operates
everywhere and is
free from danger. It
may be considered
the mother of the
universe.

I do not know its
name; I call it Tao.

it goes;

going means reaching
afar;

reaching afar means
return.

Therefore the Way is
great,

heaven is great,

earth is great,

and kingship is also
great.

Among domains are
four greats,

of which kingship is
one.

Humanity emulates
earth,

earth emulates heaven,

heaven emulates the
Way,

the Way emulates
Nature.

beings).

The name Great befits
(proportionally) four
(superimposed)
beings: The emperor,
the earth, heaven (the
classical Chinese
triad), and the
Principle.

flows through all
existence

And then returns to
source

It's ever at your
center

Your only true
recourse

For here begins the
universe

The earth and
humankind

Following this
greatest way

You can never be
defined

go really far is to return to
the original point.

To reach far is a return. To
go far away means to
return.

So dao is great and
far-reaching, and so is
heaven, earth and the king.

For just as dao, earth and
heaven each has its subtle
greatness, so does the ruler.

There are four great things
in the universe, and the
king is one of them. So
within the realm there are
four portions of greatness",
and one belongs to the king.

The ways of men are
conditioned by those of
earth.

The ways of earth, by those
of heaven.

The ways of heaven by
those of dao,

and the ways of dao by the
Self-so's

If forced to give it a
name, I shall call it
Great.

Now being great
means functioning
everywhere.
Functioning
everywhere means
far-reaching. Being
far-reaching means
returning to the
original point.

Therefore Tao is
great Heaven is great.
Earth is great. And
the king is also great.

Man models himself
after Earth. Earth
models itself after
Heaven. Heaven
models itself after
Tao. And Tao models
itself after Nature.

Gravity Is the Root
of Lightness

Gravity is the root of
lightness;
calm is the master of
excitement.

Thereby do
exemplary people
travel all day
without leaving their
equipment.
Though they have a
look of

The heavy is the base
(root) of the light.
Stillness is the prince
of movement. (These
things should be
always united in a
just temperament).

Therefore a wise
prince, when he
travels (in his light
carriage), never
separates himself
from the heavy
wagons which carry
his baggage.

The naked center
doesn't change

Its quietude is
absolute

Yet from it spring all
things that move

This bare awareness
is the root

Can you go about all
day

And never leave your
true

The solid is the
platform of the light,
and the heavy is the
root of the light.

(Maybe firm
integrity has to be the
basis of light
frivolity).

Quiet strength rules
over activity, the
not-so-active could
be the big boss of the
hasty.

So the wise man
travels all day and
never leaves his
baggage;

he who travels all
day hardly likes to be
separated from his
provision-chart:

The heavy is the root
of the light. The
tranquil is the ruler of
the hasty.

Therefore the sage
travels all day
Without leaving his
baggage.

prosperity,
their resting place is
transcendent.

What can be done
about heads of state
who take the world
lightly in their own
selfinterest?

Lack of gravity loses
servants of state;
instability loses
heads of state.

However beautiful
the landscape
through which he
passes, he takes care
to lodge only in
peaceful places.

Alas, how could an
emperor behave so
foolishly,
losing all authority
by dint of frivolity,
and all the rest
through his
waywardness?

abode

No matter how
enticing are

The splendors of the
road?

Don't think that you
can run around

And act a perfect fool

Just see that you are
at the eye

Of nature's whirlpool

dispassionate".

So the lord with ten
thousand chariots can
seldom allow himself
to be light-spirited
and lighter than those
he rules. The ruler of
a great country
should never make
light of his body -
anywhere. In light
frivolity, the
controller's centre is
lost; in hasty action,
such self-mastery. If
the ruler is
light-hearted, the
minister will be
destroyed. If he is
light, the foundation
is lost;

If he is active, the
lord is lost. [Maybe
for ever.]

Even at the sight of
magnificent scenes
He remains leisurely
and indifferent.

How is it that a lord
with ten thousand
chariots Should
behave lightheartedly
in his empire?

If he is lighthearted,
the minister will be
destroyed. If he is
hasty, the ruler is
lost.

Good Works
Good works are trackless,
good words are flawless,
good planning isn't calculating.
What is well closed has no bolt locking it, but cannot be opened.
What is well bound has no rope confining it, but cannot be untied.
Therefore sages always consider it good to save people, so that there are no wasted humans; they always

A good walker leaves no trace, a good speaker offends no one, a good reckoner needs no tally,
an expert locksmith can make one that no one can open, an expert on knots can make them so that no one can untie them. (all specialists have their speciality, which makes their fame, from which they take their profit).
Likewise the Sage (Confucian politician), the professional

Can you walk and leave no tracks?
Make no errors when you talk?
Count without a tally?
Secure a door without a lock?
You can abandon no one
There's nothing you

A good traveller leaves no track or trace behind, nor does fit activity. So a good runner leaves no track.
Perfect speech is like a jade-worker whose tool leaves no mark. Good speech leaves no flaws.
The perfect reckoner needs no counting-slips; the good reckoner uses no counters.
The perfect, shut door is without bolt nor bar and can't be opened.
The perfect knot needs neither rope nor twine, yet can't be untied. No one can untie it.

A good traveller leaves no track or trace. A good speech leaves no flaws. A good reckoner uses no counters.
A well-shut door needs no bolts, and yet it cannot be opened. A well-tied knot needs no rope and yet none can untie it.
Therefore the sage is always good in saving men and consequently no man is rejected.

consider it good to save beings, so that there are no wasted beings.
So good people are teachers of people who are not good.
People who are not good are students of people who are good.
Those who do not honor teachers or care for students are greatly deluded, even if knowledgeable.
This is called an essential subtlety.

saviour of men and things, has his own procedures.
He considers himself as the born master of other men, regarding them as material born for his craft. Now that is to blind oneself, (to shade out the light, the Daoist principles).
Not wishing to rule, nor to appropriate, others; although wise, seeming like a madman (persisting to live in retreat); this is the essential truth.

can leave behind
In you there are no limits
You are forever unconfined
What happens is spontaneous
Good and bad are just the same
In origin identical
Beyond both praise and blame

He certainly doesn't turn his back on creatures, and consequently no man is rejected. For that reason there's no useless person.
And he is always good in saving. So nothing is rejected.
This is called following the light (of nature) - is called resorting to the light, nay, stealing some divine light.
Truly, the good man is the teacher of the bad, as they say. But the bad man is the lesson of the good, in part some material from which the good can learn. And so the imperfect is the equipment of the perfect man".
He who hardly respects or values his teacher, hardly cares for the material or loves his lesson, is gone far astray even if well versed.

He is always good in saving things and consequently nothing is rejected. This is called following the light (of Nature).
Therefore the good man is the teacher of the bad, And the bad is the material from which the good may learn.
He who does not value the teacher, Or greatly care for the material, Is greatly deluded although he may be learned. Such is the essential mystery.

Know the Male
Know the Male
Know the male, keep
the female;
be humble toward the
world.
Be humble to the
world,
and eternal power
never leaves,
returning again to
innocence.
Knowing the white,
keep the black;
be an exemplar for
the world.
Be an exemplar for
the world,
and

Being aware of one's
virile strength (knowing
that one is a cock), and yet
holding oneself willingly
in the inferior state of the
female (of the hen);
keeping oneself willingly
in the lowest place in the
empire ... To demean
oneself thus shows that
one has retained the
primordial virtue,
(absolute
disinterestedness,
participation in the
Principle).
Knowing oneself to be
enlightened, and willingly
passing oneself off as
ignorant; willingly letting
oneself be walked over ...
To behave thus is to show
that the primordial virtue
has not wavered in
oneself, that one is still
united with the first
Principle.

Know the strong but
keep the weak
The whole wide
world is born in you
You'll see just what a
child sees
A vast and
comprehensive view
Know the light but
keep the dark
And watch ten
thousand things
emerge
In you they have
their residence

"He who knows the male
(active force), yet keeps
to the female (the
passive force or
receptive element),
becomes like a ravine,
receiving all sort of
things.
Being the
all-encompassing ravine
he knows a power that
he never calls upon in
vain. This is returning to
the state of infancy.
He who knows the
white, yet keeps and
cleaves to the black
becomes the standard by
which all things are
tested, he becomes the
model for the world.
As such he has all the
time the eternal power
that never errs; and he
returns to the limitless, a
primordial nothingness.

He who knows the
male and keeps to the
female Becomes the
ravine of the world.
Being the ravine of
the world, He will
never depart from
eternal virtue, But
returns to a state of
infancy.
He who knows the
white and yet keeps
to the black Becomes
the model for the
world.

eternal power never
goes awry,
returning again to
infinity.
Knowing the
glorious, keep the
ignominious;
be open to the world.
Be open to the world,
and eternal power
suffices,
returning again to
simplicity.
Simplicity is lost to
make instruments,
which sages employ
as functionaries.
Therefore the great
fashioner does no
splitting.

To behave thus is to show
that one has the original
self-sacrifice still intact
that one is still in the state
of natural simplicity.
(The Sage will refuse
therefore the burden of
being a governor. If he is
constrained to accept such
a post, then he will remind
himself that) the
multiplicity of beings
have come from the
primordial unity by a
scattering. (That he will
never busy himself with
these diverse beings), but
govern as chief of the
officials (as prime mover),
uniquely applying himself
to general government,
without occupying
himself with details.

Where space and
time converge
Know the high but
keep the low
Humility will honor
you
Attend to your
vacuity
There's nothing else
to do
Be like an uncarved
block of wood
Don't squander your
potential
Or overlook your
vacant core
Nothing else is so
essential

or even cleaves to
ignominy,
turns into the valley that
receives into it all kind
of things. And being
such a valley he has all
the time a power that
suffices. So he returns
again to some pristine
simplicity, returns to the
state of simplicity: its the
raw, uncarved block.
Break up simple
awareness and it
becomes shaped. Next it
becomes someones tool
in the hands of the wise
man. For when a block is
sawed up it's made into
subordinates or
implements.
When the wise man uses
it, it becomes chief.
So the greatest carver
does the least cutting, as
they say. The great ruler
doesn't cut up.

Being the model for
the world, He will
never deviate from
eternal virtue, But
returns to the state of
the non-ultimate.
He who knows glory
but keeps to humility
Becomes the valley
of the world, He will
be proficient in
eternal virtue, And
returns to the state of
simplicity (uncarved
wood).
When the uncarved
wood is broken up, it
is turned into
concrete things. But
when the sage uses it,
he becomes the
leading official.
Therefore the great
ruler does not cut up.

Should You Want
Should you want to
take the world,
and contrive to do so,
I see you won't
manage to finish.
The most sublime
instrument in the
world
cannot be contrived.
Those who contrive
spoil

He who holds the
empire would, in my
view, be wishing for
failure should he
want to manipulate it
(to act positively, to
govern actively).
The empire is a
mechanism of
extreme delicacy. It
should be let go all
alone. It should not
be touched. He who
touches it, deranges
it. He who wishes to
appropriate it, loses
it.

Do you want to
change the world?
You cannot possibly
succeed
The given cannot be
improved
On this the seers are
agreed
At times you find
you're out in front
At other times you
fall behind
Sometimes you're all
commotion
But afterwards you
must unwind

Those that would
gain what's under
heaven by tampering
with it - I've seen that
they don't succeed.
For that which is
under heaven is like a
holy vessel,
dangerous to tamper
with. Those that
tamper with it, harm
it. Human
go-between is likely
to fail. Those that
grab at it lose it. Who
makes can spoil well;
who holds can lose.
Among creatures of
this world some lead
and some follow.

When one desires to
take over the empire
and act on it
(interfere with it), I
see that he will not
succeed.
The empire is a
spiritual thing, and
should not be acted
on. He who acts on it
harms it.

it;
those who ding lose
it.
So creatures
sometimes go and
sometimes follow,
sometimes puff and
sometimes blow,
are sometimes strong
and sometimes weak,
begin sometime and
end sometime;
therefore sages
remove extremes,
remove
extravagance,
remove arrogance.

When he governs, the
Sage lets all people
(and their sum, the
empire) go free
according to their
several natures, the
agile and the slow,
the ardent and the
apathetic, the strong
and the weak, the
long-lived and the
short-lived.
He limits his action
to the suppression of
excesses which
would harm the
whole, such as
power, wealth, and
ambition.

When all around is
turmoil
Just stay with the
serene
You are the quiet
center
Of the ever changing
scene
Can you see things as
they are
And let them be all
on their own?
Remain in pure
awareness
You never need to
stray from home

-
Some blow out, some
blow in; some blow
out while others
would blow in.
Some are feeling
vigorous just when
others are worn out.
Some are strong,
some are weak.
Some are loading just
when others would
be tilting out. Some
can break, some can
fall.
So the wise man
discards excess,
extravagance, and
ridiculous pride: He
discards even the
absolute, the
all-inclusive, the
extreme.

He who holds on to it
loses it.
Among creatures
some lead and some
follow. Some blow
hot and some blow
cold. Some are strong
and some are weak.
Some may break and
some may fall.
Therefore the sage
discards the
extremes, the
extravagant, and the
excessive.

Assisting Human Leaders with the Way

Those who assist human leaders with the Way

do not coerce the world with weapons, for these things are apt to backfire.

Brambles grow where an army has been;

there are always bad years after a war.

Therefore the good are effective, that is all;

they do

(of all the excesses, the most prejudicial, the most damnable, as that of weapons, war). Those who act as advisors to a prince should keep themselves from wanting to make war against a country. (For such action, calling for revenge, is always paid for dearly).

Wherever the troops stay the land produces only thorns, having been abandoned by the farm workers. Wherever a great army has passed, years of unhappiness (from famine and brigandage) follow.

There is an ancient way to lead

That just allows and does not force

For what goes out will come around

And violence will lead to wars

The one who sees completes a task

And stops

He who by dao purposes to help a ruler of men, will oppose most conquest by force of arms:

such things are wont to rebound.

Where armies are, thorns and brambles can grow.

The raising of a great host could be followed by a year of dearth.

Therefore a good general effects his purpose and next stops; for he dares not rely upon the strength of arms: he doesn't take further advantage of a victory. He fulfils his purpose and does hardly glory in things he has done; effects his purpose and doesn't boast of a thing he accomplished;

fulfils —

He who assists the ruler with Tao does not dominate the world with force. The use of force usually bring requital.

Wherever armies are stationed, briars and thorns grow. Great wars are always followed by famines.

A good (general) achieves his purpose and stops, But dares not seek to dominate the world.

He achieves his purpose but does not brag about it.

not presume to grab power thereby:

they are effective but not conceited,

effective but not proud,

effective but not arrogant.

They are effective when they have to be,

effective but not coercive.

If you peak in strength, you then age;

this, it is said, is unguided.

The unguided soon come to an end.

He stops as soon as possible, guarding himself from exploiting his force to the limit.

He does as much as is required (to reestablish peace), not for his personal advantage and fame, but from necessity and with reluctance, without any intention of increasing his power.

Any height of power is always followed by decadence. Making oneself is therefore contrary to the Principle (the source of duration). He who is lacking on this point, will not be long in coming to an end.

when it is done

Seeing all is on its own

And not controlled by anyone

The seer sees that all is well

And does not need to please

Just gives acceptance everywhere

Puts everyone at ease

an ignoble purpose, but takes no pride in something he did well; fulfils his purpose as some perhaps regrettable necessity - does it as a step that could hardly be averted and avoided.

So he effects his purpose, but hardly loves violence. Why?

Things age after reaching their prime. What has a time of vigour (and conquest) also has its time of decay. After things reach their prime, they begin to grow old, which means being contrary to dao. Furthermore, morbid violence and violence in excess could be against dao. He who is against the dao perishes young. Whatever is contrary to dao will soon perish. What's against dao will hardly survive.

He achieves his purpose but does not boast about it. He achieves his purpose but is not proud of it. He achieves his purpose but only as an unavoidable step. He achieves his purpose but does not aim to dominate.

(For) after things reach their prime, they begin to grow old, Which means being contrary to Tao. Whatever is contrary to Tao will soon perish.

Chapter 31
Thomas Cleary

Fine Weapons

Fine weapons are implements of ill omen: people may despise them, so those with the Way do not dwell with them.

Therefore the place of honor for the cultured is on the left, while the honored place for the martialist is on the right.

Weapons, being instruments of ill omen, are not the tools of the cultured, who use them only when unavoidable.

They consider it best to be aloof;

they win without beautifying it.

Those who beautify

Chapter 31
Derek Bryce

The best weapons are ill-omened instruments that all beings hold in fear. Therefore those who conform themselves to the Principle do not use them.

In times of peace, the prince puts the civil minister he honours on his left (the place of honour); but even in times of war, he puts the military commander on his right (which is not the place of honour, even though he is exercising his function).

Weapons are disastrous instruments. A wise prince uses them only with reluctance and from necessity. He prefers always a modest peace to a glorious victory.

No one should think that victory is a good thing. He who thinks that, shows that he has the heart of an assassin. Such a man would not be fit to reign over the empire.

Chapter 31
Jim Claffelder

Weapons lead to violence

Which everyone despises

Avoid them altogether

Allow no compromises

If use of weapons has to be

When enemies just leave no choice

Use them but reluctantly

In victory do not rejoice

Ascendancy brings sorrow

And

Chapter 31
Tormond Byrn

Fine weapons are instruments of evil as soldiers can be: quite ill-omened things, often hated.

Those with fine dao turn away from weapons that are most often hated.

The gentleman favours the left hand side among people in peace; peace people are of good birth. In a fair peace the symbolic left is the place of honour. Yes, a good ruler honours the left and its good omens when at home, but in war this is reversed: On military occasions he favours the right side as the place of war honour. And so he honours the right of bad omens.

The durable, even when he conquers, does hardly regard weapons as lovely things. Weapons and soldiers can be bad and evil-doing tools.

Chapter 31
Wing-Tsit Chan

Fine weapons are instruments of evil. They are hated by men. Therefore those who possess Tao turn away from them.

The good ruler when at home honours the left. When at war he honours the right.

Weapons are instruments of evil, not the instruments of a good ruler. When he uses them unavoidably, he regards calm restraint as the best principle.

Even when he is victorious, he does not regard it as praiseworthy, For to praise victory is to delight in the slaughter of men.

it

enjoy killing people.

Those who enjoy killing cannot get their will of the world.

The left is favored for auspicious things, the right for things of ill omen:

so the subordinate general is on the left, the top general on the right.

That means when you are in ascendancy of power

you handle it as you would a mourning.

When you have killed many people,

you weep for them in sorrow.

When you win a war, you celebrate by mourning.

(Now when the emperor receives two military officers together), the one of subordinate rank (who only acts on superior orders, and is therefore less ill-omened) is placed on the left. The commanding officer is placed on the right, that is, in the first place according to the funeral rites, (the place of the chief mourner).

For it behooves one who has killed many men to weep tears of lamentation for them. The only place really fitting for a conquering general is that of the chief mourner (leading the mourning for those whose death he has caused).

When, in the beginning, in this visible world, the Principle imparted itself in the production of (sentient) beings with names, it did not produce them in a way that exhausted itself (but only as tenuous prolongations, its mass remaining intact).

triumph doesn't carry pleasure

It severs you from wholeness

And robs you of your real treasure

Victory is like a funeral

Where loss of life must make you sad

For putting other people down

Never ought to make you glad

They're not often the tools of the gentleman and good ruler.

To hold them dear means to delight in them, and so to delight in slaughter of men.

And he who delights in the slaughter of men will never get what he looks for out of those that live and function under heaven. In ugly victory there's no beauty,

and who calls it handsome perhaps preaches slaughter.

Use of soldiers [and police] can't be helped, best policy is calm restraint.

Who delights in the slaughter of men wont succeed, wont succeed in ruling the world; and slaying of multitudes should be mourned.

A host that has slain men had better be received with grief and mourning rites; he that has conquered in battle had better be received and celebrated with some mournful funeral custom.. A victory is the grand occasion for funerals.

He who delights in the slaughter of men will not succeed in the empire.

In auspicious affairs, the left is honoured. In inauspicious affairs, the right is honoured. The lieutenant general stands on the left. The senior general stands on the right. This is to say that the arrangement follows that of funeral ceremonies.

For the slaughter of the multitude, let us weep with sorrow and grief. For a victory, let us observe the occasion with funeral ceremonies.

The Way Is Eternally Nameless

The Way is eternally nameless.

Though simplicity is small,
the world cannot subordinate it.

If lords and monarchs can keep to it,
all beings will naturally resort to them.

Heaven and earth combine,
thus showering sweet dew.

No humans

The Principle has no name of its own. It is nature. This nature so unmanifest is stronger than anything.

If princes and emperors were to conform themselves to it, all beings would collaborate with them spontaneously;
heaven and earth would act in perfect harmony, sprinkling

Awareness is not limited

It's like an uncarved block of wood

With infinite potential

Beyond all usefulness for good

If leaders could stay centered

In awareness pure and plain

Best dao is absolute and eternal. As such it has neither name nor fame.

Its uncunning, cute naiveté, the fabled raw block of wood, and it cant be used by anybody. None in the whole world can master and make use of such basic simplicity. Yet, though seemingly of small value, it could be greater than anything in the universe.

Good kings and barons can keep such unspoiled, inborn nature. If kings and barons would but hold on to it, all beings and things would submit to them well of their own accord. Yes, the best let heaven and earth join, so that the mystic sweet rain falls, all the time beyond the command of men, yet evenly upon all. Let heaven and earth unite to drip sweet dew.

Tao is eternal and has no name. Though its simplicity seems insignificant, none in the world can master it.

If kings and barons would hold on to it, all things would submit to the spontaneously.

Heaven and earth unite to drip sweet dew. Without the command of men, its drips evenly over all.

command it;
it is even by nature.

Start fashioning, and there are names;
once names also exist,
you should know when to stop.

By knowing when to stop,
you are not endangered.

The Way is to the world
as rivers and oceans to valley streams.

a sweet dew (the best possible omen); the people would be governable without the need for constraint.

The Principle is, with reference to the diversity of beings in the world, like the mass of great rivers and oceans with reference to trickles and rivulets of water.

This world would be as nourishing

As nature's gentle rain

Everyone would be at peace

And always living in the whole

Opposition and division

Could never take their toll

harmony.

A human civilisation can rise once there are names [principles].

Once the block is carved, there will be such names; they're wide differentiations of things. But as soon as there are [principles and neatly differentiated] names, know that it's time to stop. Its well to know where to stop for calm and poise. As soon as there are names [and study] it's time to stop.

By knowing when it's time to stop, much danger could be avoided.

In the world dao can be likened to rivers that turn into wider rivers and eventually course into some sea. All will come to and be clasped by one and more such dao rivers -and to [some] dao all under heaven will come, as streams and torrents flow into a great river or sea [of universal dao].

As soon as there were regulations and institutions, there were names. As soon as there were names, know that it is time to stop. It is by knowing when to stop that one can be free from danger.

Analogically, Tao in the world may be compared to rivers and streams running into the sea.

Those Who Know Others

Those who know others are wise;

those who know themselves are enlightened.

Those who overcome others are powerful;

those who overcome themselves are

Knowing others is wisdom, but knowing oneself is superior wisdom, (one's own nature being most hidden and profound).

Imposing one's will on others is strength; but imposing it on oneself is superior strength (one's own passions being the most difficult to subdue).

Being satisfied (content with what destiny has given), is true wealth;

It may be said that you are wise

To see yourself as others do

But you are wiser still to see

From your own central

He who knows others is learned;

but he who knows himself is wise, nay, in the end it could be illumined.

He who conquers others has strength of muscles;

To conquer oneself is hard. So he who conquers himself is strong.

To be content with what one has is to feel rich; so let the contented feel rich.

Next: He who works, may eventually succeed. And he one who acts with vigour has will.

He who knows others is wise; He who knows himself is enlightened.

He who conquers others has physical strength. He who conquers himself is strong.

He who is contented is rich.

strong.

Those who are contented are rich;

those who act strongly have will.

Those who do not lose their place endure;

those who die without perishing live long.

being master of oneself (bending oneself to the dispositions of destiny) is true character.

Staying in one's (natural) place (that which destiny has given), makes for a long life. After death, not ceasing to be, is true longevity, (which is the lot of those who have lived in conformity with nature and destiny).

point of view

Then you see you have it all

The riches that are always here

Belong to you completely

Because your vision is so clear

Even he who works through sordid violence can get his way - The determined one has strength of will.

What stays in its place can endure. He who doesn't lose his centre can last quite long, he who hardly loses his place (with such as dao).

The one who dies but doesn't really perish enjoys long life. He who dies yet (his power) remains has long life. When such a one dies he should hardly be thought of as [too] lost; there's no other longevity [than long life].

He who acts with vigour has will.

He who does not lose his place (with Tao) will endure. He who dies but does not really perish enjoys long life.

The Great Way is Universal;
The Great Way is universal
it can apply to the left or the right.
All beings depend on it for life,
and it does not refuse.
Its accomplishments fulfilled,
it does not dwell on them.
It lovingly nurtures all beings,
but does

The great Principle extends itself in all directions.
It lends itself willingly to the genesis of all beings (its participants).
When a work is accomplished, it does not attribute it to itself.
It nourishes all beings with kindness, without imposing itself on them as a master (for having nourished them; leaving them free; not exacting any degrading return from —

The empty center's everywhere
It flows both left and right
It brings to pass ten thousand things
And yet it never leaves your sight
It welcomes everything around
On nothing does it make a claim

Some great dao can flow everywhere. Like a flood it can go left or right. Like a drifting boat it can go this way or that.
All things [eventually] derive their life from it. It hardly denies or disowns them.
It accomplishes its task, but seem to claim no credit for it. It hardly takes possession of anyone, either.
So though it covers all there is like some garment, it hardly takes possession. It can clothe and feed all beings but hardly claims to be guru over them.
Therefore it can perhaps be called low and quite free from insignificant desires.
To turn into the home of all things, dont make any outer claims.

The Great Tao flows everywhere. It may go left or right.
All things depend on it for life, and it does not turn away from them. It accomplishes its task, but does not claim credit for it.

not act as their ruler.
As it has no desire, it can be called small.
As all beings take to it,
yet it does not act as their ruler,
it can be called great.
Therefore sages never contrive greatness;
that is why they can become so great.

them).
Because of its constant disinterestedness, one might think it would become diminished. This is not so.
All beings to who it is so liberal, run towards it. It therefore finds itself magnified (through this universal trust).
The Sage imitates this conduct. He, also, makes himself small (through his disinterestedness and his delicate reserve), and acquires thereby true greatness.

It's in the heart of each and all
This ultimate without a name
Some can see that it is great
And some will say that it's obscure
It is your real identity
Simplicity that will endure

(Implied; cf. Y)
See into how dao is by non-desiring empty mind. (Cf. Y)
Ten thousand [hungry] creatures obey a dao master and his ways, though they hardly understand it or how. Dao is called great. And the man who lives it or a dao repertoire is called great as well.
The wise man never strives [verbally] for the great. To the end the wise dao man doesn't claim any outer greatness. Thus [some degree of subtle Vossa-] greatness is installed.
And the wise man never at any time hardly ever makes a show of greatness. By such a dogged, keen strategy some [clowns] achieves greatness.

It clothes and feeds all things but does not claim to be master over them.
Always without desires it may be called the Small.
All things come to it and it does not master them; it may be called the Great.
Therefore (the sage) never strives himself for the great, and thereby the great is achieved.

Holding the Great Image
When holding the Great Image,
the world goes on
and on without harm,
peaceful, even,
tranquil.
Where there is music
and dining,
passing travelers
stop;
but the issue of

Because he resembles the great prototype (the Principle, through his disinterested devotion), all come to the Sage. He welcomes them all, does them good, and gives them rest, peace, and happiness.
Music and good cheer may hold up a passer-by for but a night,

Totality will be with you
If you can see the simple presence
Although there's danger all around
You give complete acceptance
Good music, food and company
Are welcome when you're

Hold the great symbol and great form of dao know-how. He who visualises or holds the great symbol form at its best can go about his work (in such as his empire), yet without doing harm. An then all the world follows. At last a lot of people will come and meet no harm. All in peace, quietness and security, commonwealth. All can enjoy comfort and health.
Sound of music, smell of good dishes will make the passing stranger pause.

Hold fast to the great form (Tao), And all the world will come. They come and will encounter no harm; But enjoy comfort, peace, and health.
When there are music and dainties, Passing

the Way
is so plain as to be flavorless.
When you look at it, it is invisible;
when you listen to it, it is inaudible;
when you use it, it cannot be exhausted.

(since sensual pleasures are fleeting and leave nothing behind).
Whereas the exposition of the great principle of disinterested devotion, simple and gentle, which charms neither the eyes nor the ears, pleases, engraves itself, and is of an inexhaustible fecundity in matters of practical application.

traveling
The inner truth seems tasteless
Yet it produces everything
You look and you see nothing
You listen and hear silence
Its use is inexhaustible
It's ever worthy of reliance

Yes, offer music and dainties, very good things to eat and the [odd], passing and wayfaring stranger will stay.
How different the words that dao gives forth! So thin, insipid, so flavour- or tasteless! Still dao is mild to the taste.
Looked at, it can't be seen. So look at dao; it's quite imperceptible. If one looks for dao, there's hardly anything solid to see.
If one listens for it, there's nothing loud to hear. We listen to this inaudible [thing].

strangers will stay.
But the words uttered by Tao, How insipid and tasteless! We look at it; it is imperceptible. We listen to it; it is inaudible. We use it; it is inexhaustible.

Should You Want to Contain

Should you want to contain something, you must deliberately let it expand.

Should you want to weaken something, you must deliberately let it grow strong.

Should you want to eliminate something, you must deliberately allow it to

The beginning of contraction necessarily follows the maximum of expansion. Weakness follows strength, decadence follows prosperity, depravation follows opulence.

This is a subtle insight (that many do not wish to see). All preceding strength and superiority is expiated by subsequent debility and inferiority.

You cannot be diminished

Unless you've been inflated

You cannot be defeated

Unless you've been elated

You cannot be belittled

Unless you've been esteemed

Unless you're wholly missing

What's in the end to be shrunk can first be stretched. The one who is to be made to dwindle (in power) can first be caused to expand; and then it's necessary first to expand.

Whatever is to be weakened must begin by being made strong [enough for it first of all].

He who is to be laid low can first be exalted to power. So: first promote, next destroy. Or: To destroy, first promote.

In order to contract, It is necessary first to expand. In order to weaken, It is necessary first to strengthen. In order to destroy, It is necessary first to promote.

flourish.

Should you want to take something away, you must deliberately grant it.

This is called subtle illumination.

Flexibility and yielding

overcome adamant coerciveness.

Fish shouldn't be taken from the depths;

the effective tools of the nation

shouldn't be shown to others.

More calls for less, excess calls for deficit.

A fish should not leave the depths (where it lives ignored but in security, in order to show itself at the surface where it could be harpooned). A state should not show its resources (if it does not wish the others to turn against it in order to crush it).

You cannot be redeemed

The soft and slow can overcome

The rigid and the hard and fast

Just see your inner emptiness

For nothing else is made to last

He who would be a taker must begin as a giver.

And this is the fine art. of dimming" one's light.

According to this [set-up] the soft overcomes the hard; and the weak, the strong. [Such things can happens, but most often not, or what?]

Fish should be left in the deep pool, not taken away from water. And sharp weapons of the state should not be displayed, but left where nobody can see them.

In order to grasp, It is necessary first to give.

This is called subtle light. The weak and the tender overcome the hard and the strong.

Fish should not be taken away from water. And sharp weapons of state should not be displayed to the people.

The Way Is Always
Uncontrived

The Way is always
uncontrived,
yet there's nothing it
doesn't do.

If lords and
monarchs could keep
to

it, all beings would
evolve
spontaneously.

When they

The Principle is
always non-acting
(not acting actively),
and yet it does
everything (without
seeming to
participate).

If the prince and the
lords could govern
like that (without
poking their fingers
in it), all beings
would become
spontaneously
perfect (by returning
to nature).

Only see you're
doing nothing

Yet not a thing is left
undone

For all things happen
on their own

In you who are the all
in one

If leaders could be
centered

All

The dao never does; it
takes no action.
Through it everything
is done, yet there's
nothing left undone.

If good kings and
barons would master
some fit dao and keep
it, all things in the
world should
transform
spontaneously.

When reformed and
rising to action, let all
influenced be
restrained by the
blankness of the
unnamed, the
nameless pristine
simplicity.

Tao invariably takes
no action, and yet
there is nothing left
undone.

If kings and barons
can keep it, all things
will transform
spontaneously.

have evolved and
want to act,

I would stabilize
them with nameless
simplicity.

Even nameless
simplicity would not
be wanted.

By not wanting, there
is calm,

and the world will
straighten itself.

It would only remain
to call them back to
unnamed nature (to
the primordial
simplicity of the
Principle) each time
they showed any
tendency to come out
of this state (by
acting). In this state
of unnamed nature
there are no desires.

When there are no
desires all is
peaceful, and the
state is governed by
itself.

ten thousand things
would thrive

By seeing what is
natural

All creation comes
alive

Everyone would be
content

With living simply
every day

Desires would be
moderate

And peace would be
the only way

Yes, if after being
transformed they
should desire to act,
someone has to
restrain them with
simplicity that has no
name.

Its an unnamed
blankness; it could
bring dispassion; As
such nameless pristine
simplicity is stripped
of desire. So to be
truly, artfully
dispassionate, be free
of desires and still.
Simple wit and sense
is free of desires.

If, after
transformation, they
should desire to be
active, I would
restrain them with
simplicity, which has
no name.

Simplicity, which has
no name, is free of
desires, Being free of
desires, it is tranquil.
And the world will
be at peace of its own
accord.

Chapter 38
Wing-Tsit Chan

The man of superior virtue is not (conscious of) his virtue, And in this way he really possesses virtue. The man of inferior virtue never loses (sight of) his virtue, And in this way he loses his virtue.

The man of superior virtue takes no action, but has no ulterior motive to do so. The man of inferior virtue takes action, and has an ulterior motive to do so.

The man of superior humanity takes action, but has no ulterior motive to do so. The man of superior righteousness takes action, and has an ulterior motive to do so.

The man of superior propriety takes action, And when people do not respond to it, he will stretch his arms and force it on —

them.

Therefore when Tao is lost, only then does the doctrine of virtue arise. When virtue is lost, only then does the doctrine of humanity arise. When humanity is lost, only then does the doctrine of righteousness arise. When righteousness is lost, only then does the doctrine of propriety arise.

Now, propriety is a superficial expression of loyalty and faithfulness, and the beginning of disorder. Those who are the first to know have the flowers of Tao but are the beginning of ignorance.

For this reason the great man dwells in the thick, and does not rest with the thin. He dwells in the fruit, and does not rest with the flower. Therefore he rejects the one, and accepts the other.

Return Is the
Movement of the
Way

Return is the
movement of the
Way;
yielding is the

Going back (towards
the Principle) is the
type of movement
characteristic of
those who conform
themselves to the
Principle.
Attenuation is the
result of their being
conformed to the
Principle.

All is born of
emptiness
Manifests and has its

Reversion is the
action of dao. In dao
the only motion is a
return;

and the one useful
quality is named soft
[or polite] gentleness,
So

Reversion is the
action of Tao.
Weakness is the
function of Tao.

function of the Way.

All things in the
world are born of
being;

being is born of
nonbeing.

Considering all that
exists is born of
simple being, and
that being is born of
formless non-being,
they tend, in
diminishing
themselves without
cease, to go back to
primordial
simplicity.

day

Then yields and
surrenders

Returns and dies
away

Commentary

polite or weak
gentleness [or
humility] is the
function of dao.

The creatures and
things of this world
come from being.
And being from
not-yet-being. though
all

All things in the
world come from
being. And being
comes from
non-being.

Chapter 41
Thomas Cleary

Chapter 41
Derek Bryce

Chapter 41
Jim Clatfelder

Chapter 41
Tormond Byrn

Chapter 41
Wing-Tsit Chan

When Superior People Hear of the Way

When superior people hear of the Way,

They carry it out with diligence.

When middling people hear of the Way,

it sometimes seems to be there, sometimes not.

When lesser people hear of the Way,

they ridicule it greatly.

If they didn't laugh at it,

it wouldn't be the Way.

So there are constructive sayings on this:

The Way of illumination seems

When a well-read person of high caliber hears about the return to the Principle, he applies himself to it with zeal. A person of medium caliber applies himself to it indecisively.

An inferior person ridicules it. That such a person should ridicule it, is a mark of the truth of this doctrine. The fact that they do not understand it, shows its transcendence.

They say in the proverb: Those who have understood the Principle are as if blind; those who tend towards it are as if disoriented; those who have reached it seem like common people.

When seers see their nothingness

They never let it out of sight

But others see it now and then

And miss out on its true delight

Still others only laugh it off

And look at it with ridicule

It wouldn't be the real truth

If it weren't laughed at by the fool

The brightest way seems

dark —

ne —

s —

s

When the highest of men hear of dao and truth they put it into practice quite diligently.

When the common types hear of dao, they seem to be in two minds about it, half believing, aware and unaware of some.

When the lowest types hear of dao, they ridicule or laugh loudly - but if they did not laugh, it would be no dao.

The proverb has it:

The way out into the light often looks dark; one who understands dao seems dull, as dao which is bright appears to be dark.

The dao which goes forward appears to fall backward; the one who is advanced (in dao) seems to slip backwards; the way that goes ahead often looks as if it went back.

He who works and moves on the even dao [co-path] seems to go up and down; the least hilly way often looks as if it went thus, as level dao appears uneven.

When the highest type of men hear Tao, The diligently practice it. When the average type of men hear Tao, They half believe in it.

When the lowest type of men hear Tao, They laugh heartily at it. If they did not laugh at it, it would not be Tao.

Therefore there is the established saying: The Tao which is bright appears to be dark. The Tao which goes forward appears to fall backward. The Tao which is level appears uneven.

dark,

the Way of advancement seems retiring,

the Way of equality seems to categorize;

higher virtue seems empty,

great purity seems ignominious,

broad virtue seems insufficient,

constructive virtue seems careless.

Simple honesty seems changeable,

great range has no boundaries,

great vessels are finished late;

the great sound has a rarefied tone,

the great image has no form,

the Way hides in namelessness.

This is because great virtue hollows itself like a valley, the great light voluntarily dims itself, vast virtue seems defective, solid virtue seems incapable.

Therefore the Sage hides his qualities beneath a somewhat repulsive exterior. He who goes by these appearances will be quite misled. Like a square so big that its corners are invisible, like an enormous vase that is never finished, like a great meaning hidden in a feeble sound, like a great shape that cannot be grasped;

the Sage resembles the Principle. - Now the Principle is latent and has no name, but through its gentle communication, everything is produced. It is the same, in proportion, for the Sage.

Just going on seems like retreat

The simple way seems difficult

Capacity seems like defeat

Clarity can seem obscure

And love seem not to care

Totality seems not enough

And truth can seem to err

Awareness doesn't have a name

To all appearances is null

Yet it produces everything

And so this empty place is full

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

—

Great virtue appears like a valley (hollow). Great purity appears like disgrace.

Far-reaching virtue appears as if insufficient.

Solid virtue appears as if unsteady. True substance appears to be changeable. The great square has no corners. The great implement (or talent) is slow to finish (or mature). Great music sounds faint. Great form has no shape.

The Way Produces One

The Way produces one;

one produces two, two produce three, three produce all beings:

all beings bear yin and embrace yang, with a mellowing energy for harmony.

The things people dislike

are only to be alone, lacking,

When the Principle has emitted its virtue, the latter begins to evolve according to two alternating modalities. This evolution produces (or condenses) the median air (tenuous matter). From tenuous matter, under the influence of the two modalities yin and yang, all sentient beings are produced.

Coming out from the yin (from strength) they pass to

Awareness comes from nothingness

So all can see it's plainly one

Contains all opposition

Ten thousand things are now begun

All these things embrace the void

And face the manifest

Achieving thus true harmony

They find existence truly blessed

No

Dao gave birth to the one; the one gave birth successively to two things, three things, up the everything, everybody and the whole world we know.

The ten thousand things carry the yin as some back or behind, and hug the yang in front. Through the blending of the pervading principles as some abstract union, and by a further blending [designing] the material force (ki) they can gain [sound] harmony. And so the union in harmony gets strong [and defences].

In other words, living beings can't turn their backs to the shade [such as cooling yin] without having the sun on their bellies [it could be invigorating yang], and it's on such (yin-yang) blending of so-called breaths that [most] harmony depends.

Tao produced the One. The One produced the two. The two produced the three. And the three produced the ten thousand things.

The ten thousand things carry the yin and embrace the yang, and through the blending of the material force they achieve harmony.

People hate to be children without parents, lonely people without spouses, or

and unworthy;

yet these are what monarchs call themselves.

Therefore people may gain from loss, and may lose from gain.

What others teach, I also teach.

The strong cannot master their death:

I take this to be the father of teachings.

the yang (to the act), through the influence of the two modalities on matter.

What men dislike is being alone, unique, incapable, (in obscurity and abasement), and yet emperors and princes are designated by these terms, (which imply humility without debasement).

Beings diminish themselves by wanting to augment themselves, and they are augmented through diminishing themselves.

one wants to be considered

Empty and alone

Yet that's exactly what the seers

Say they have been shown

And violence is not the way

I give you this instruction

Those who live by violence

Will bring about their own destruction

Yet princes and dukes style themselves so, and call themselves by these names.

Truly, things are often increased by seeking to diminish them and diminished by seeking to increase them." And sometimes things are benefited by being taken away from and suffer by being added to. And so it often happens that things can gain by losing and lose by gaining.

What others have taught, I teach also:

"Violent and fierce people hardly die a natural [elegant] death."

Yet, show me a man of violence that came to a good end, and I will take him for my teacher. I shall make all this the father (basis) of my teaching. [Uha.]

men without food to eat, And yet kings and lords call themselves by these names.

Therefore it is often the case that things gain by losing and lose by gaining.

What others have taught, I teach also: "Violent and fierce people do not die a natural death." I shall make this the father of my teaching.

What Is Softest in the World
What is softest in the world
drives what is hardest in the world.
Nonbeing enters where

Always and everywhere it is the soft that wears the hard (as water wears stone). Non-being penetrates even where there are no cracks (as in the most homogeneous bodies such as metal and stone).

Overcome by yielding
The weak can overcome the strong
For only absence can provide
The place where everything belongs
And

The softest things in the world overcome the hardest things in the world. The softest substance radiates through the hardest. Also, what's most yielding can eventually overwhelm the hardest.

Formless penetrates no-crevice; substanceless it can enter where there's no space; all this could be not-yet-being entering and jostling non-space. That's how I know the value of action that's actionless.

The softest things in the world overcome the hardest things in the world. Non-being penetrates that in which there is no space.

there is no room;
that is how we know noncontrivance enhances.
Unspoken guidance and uncontrived enhancement
are reached by few in the world.

From that I conclude the supreme effectiveness of non-action.

Silence and inaction - few men come to understand their effectiveness.

thus it is that I can see
The worthiness of not contending
Yet few will ever comprehend
The potency of bending

Through this I [also] know the benefit or advantage of taking no action.

There can be [sad] teaching without words. To teach without words can be best. Still few can understand such stuff. And there can be solid value in action that's actionless, or the advantage of taking no action. Yes, the [said] benefit of taking no action is without compare. Few can understand it.

Through this I know the advantage of taking no action.

Few in the world can understand the teaching without words and the advantage of taking no action.

Name or Body Which is closer, your name or your body? Which is more, your body or your possessions? Which is more destructive, gain or loss? Extreme fondness means great expense, and abundant	Is not the body more important that reputation? Is life not of more consideration that wealth? Is it wise to risk a great loss for a small advantage? He who is a great lover, wears out (his heart).	Which of these means more to you Integrity or reputation? Are gain and loss not equally Responsible for limitation? Everything that you possess Is surely transitory Just be pleased with	Fame or one's own self, which matters most? Nay, which does one love more? Which should one love more, fame or one's own life? Which is more valuable, one's own life or wealth? One's own self or things bought, the solid goods, which should really count most? Which is worse, gain or loss? Could it be loss (of self) or possession which is the greater evil? [Which gain is the greater evil here?] Therefore: he who loves most spends most.	Which does one love more, fame or one's own life? Which is more valuable, one's own life or wealth? Which is worse, gain or loss? Therefore he who has lavish desires will spend extravagantly.
---	--	---	--	--

possessions mean much loss. If you know when you have enough, you will not be disgraced. If you know when to stop, you will not be endangered. It is possible thereby to live long.	He who amasses great wealth, heads toward ruin (by theft or confiscation). Whereas he who is modest courts no disgrace; he who is moderate does not perish, but endures.	emptiness And witness inner bliss and glory You know that you are always safe If only you can be contented With awareness as capacity And with all that is presented	He who has lavish desires could spend extravagantly. He who hoards much could lose much. Who hoards much is in for losing heavily if who has hoarded most could suffer the heaviest loss. The contented man could meet no disgrace; Who stops in time knows when to stop. Who stops in time nothing can harm if free from danger he can long endure and feel forever safe and secure. He can long endure who stays forever safe and secure -	He who hoards will lose most heavily. He who is contented suffers no disgrace. He who knows when to stop is free from danger. Therefore he can long endure.
--	---	---	---	--

Great Completeness
Seems Incomplete

Great completeness
seems incomplete;

its use is never
exhausted.

Great fullness seems
empty;

its use is never
ended.

Great

Accomplished,
beneath an imperfect
exterior. Giving, (of
himself) without
becoming worn out.
Filled up, without
appearing to be so,
And pouring out
without being
emptied. Very
straight, beneath a
bent air;

most able, behind an
awkward appearance;
highly perspicacious,
with an embarrassed
exterior.

Wholeness seems
like imperfection

Yet its usefulness is
sure

Fullness seems quite
empty

But it is certain to
endure

True straightness can
seem twisted

True wisdom does
not seem to know

What's most perfect
[ambivalence] seems to
be incomplete; [its]
highest perfection is
never impaired. The
perfect seems to have
something missing; [so
have something
missing]. Highest
perfection is like
imperfection, but its
use is never impaired,
nor its utility [at times].

What's most full
[opening] seems
empty; its use will
never fail.

The greatest abundance
seems meagre indeed,
but its use will never
fail.

What's most straight
seems devious, maybe
crooked.

What is most perfect
seems to be
incomplete; But its
utility is unimpaired.
What is most full
seems to be empty;
But its usefulness is
inexhaustible. What
is most straight
seems to be crooked.

directness seems
restrained,

great skill seems
inept,

great eloquence
seems inarticulate.

Movement
overcomes cold,

stillness overcomes
heat.

Clear stillness is right
for the world.

This is the Sage.

Movement beats the
cold (warms one up),
rest overcomes heat
(refreshes). The
withdrawn life of the
Sage rectifies all the
empire (strikes at the
root of its
depravation.

Great eloquence
seems halting

Great darkness seems
to be aglow

Can you see that
emptiness

Contains all
oppositions?

Like hot and cold and
fast and slow?

All differences and
all conditions?

The greatest cleverness
appears like stupidity,
[(Demon skill seems
like clumsiness. Apt
skill seems clumsy,
true cleverness seems
clumsy.)]

The greatest
[harlequin] eloquence
seems to stutter or
seems like stuttering.

Hasty movement
overcomes cold.

Keeping still can
overcome heat.
Tranquillity and
staying still can
overcome heat.

The greatest skill
seems to be clumsy.
The greatest
eloquence seems to
stutter.

Hasty movement
overcomes cold,
(But) tranquility
overcomes heat. By
being greatly
tranquil, One is
qualified to be the
ruler of the world.

When the World Has
the Way
When the world has
the Way,
running horses are
retired to till the
fields.
When the world
lacks the Way,
war-horses are bred
in

When the Principle
reigns (in perfect
peace), war horses
work in the fields.
When the Principle is
forgotten, (war
horses are the order
of the day) And they
are raised even in the
suburbs of the towns.
To give in to one's
covetousness (And
this includes the
mania for waging
war), is the worst of
crimes.

When the absolute is
cherished
Horses graze on the
open green
When the absolute is
lost
Only steeds of war
are

When dao reigns in the
kingdom, galloping
horses are turned back to
fertilise certain fields
with their manure. If the
world in accord with
dao, racing horses are
turned back to pull
refuse carts.
When the world hardly
lives in accord with dao,
dao doesn't prevail or
win. Next war horses
will be reared even on a
sacred hill below the city
walls, and blatant
cavalry will frolic in the
countryside, driving and
riding pestering war
horses in suburbs in
between.

When Tao prevails in
the world, galloping
horses are turned
back to fertilize (the
fields with the dung).
When Tao does not
prevail in the world,
war horses thrive in
the suburbs.

the countryside.
No crime is greater
than approving of
greed;
no calamity is greater
than discontent,
no fault is greater
than possessiveness.
So the satisfaction of
contentment is
always enough.

Not to know how to
control oneself, is the
worst of nasty things.
The worst of faults is
to want more,
always.
Those who know
how to say 'enough is
enough', are always
content.

seen
No calamity exceeds
desire
And always wanting
more
Can you not see you
have enough
And live in plenitude
galore?

Dao does hardly prevail
if war is on in city
suburbs.
No lure is greater than to
possess what others
want.
There's no greater guilt
than [sudden] discontent.
There's (...) greater
disaster than greed.
[Eventually] there's
hardly a greater sin than
desire for possession.
No disaster could be
greater than [...] to be
content with what one
has [in dire need and
disabling poverty]. No
presage of [airy] evil is
greater than men
wanting to get more.

There is no calamity
greater than lavish
desires. There is no
greater guilt than
discontentment. And
there is no greater
disaster than greed.
He who is contented
with contentment is
always contented.

Without Even Going
out the Door
They know the world
without even going
out the door.
They see the sky and
its pattern
without

Without going out by
the door, one can
know the whole
world; without
looking through the
window, one can
become aware of the
way of heaven
(principles which
rule all things).

No need to go
outside a door
To see totality
Or look out of a
window
For seeing what will
always be
Going

One can know what's
happening all over
the world without
going out of doors.
One can see the dao
of the big wide
beyond here without
looking out of one's
windows, and see all
the ways of that

One may know the
world without going
out of doors. One
may see the Way of
Heaven without
looking through the
windows.

even looking out the
window.
The further out it
goes, the less
knowledge is;
therefore sages know
without going,
name without seeing,
complete without
striving.

- The further one
goes, the less one
learns.
The Sage gets there
without having taken
a step to reach it. He
knows before having
seen, through
superior principles.
He achieves, without
having acted, through
his transcendent
action.

out you go astray
At home and center
all is one
The seer doesn't have
to do
To see that
everything is done

beyond-here.
Then, the further one
travels the less one
knows.
So the wise man can
[at times] arrive
without going and
know without going
about; he can
understand much
without seeing -
or achieve much
without [visible]
action.

The further one goes,
the less one knows.
Therefore the sage
knows without going
about, Understands
without seeing, And
accomplishes without
any action.

For Learning You
Gain Daily

For learning you gain
daily;

for the Way you lose
daily.

Losing and losing,
thus you reach
noncontrivance;
be uncontrived, and
nothing is

By studying, every
day one increases
(useless and injurious
particular notions, in
one's memory); by
concentrating on the
Principle, they are
diminished every
day.

Pushed to the limit,
this diminution ends
in non-action, (the
consequence of the
absence of particular
ideas).

In going after
learning

Something's added
every day

For resting in the
ultimate

Everything must
drop away

Day by day do less
and less

Until nothingness is
seen

All occurs quite

The student of
knowledge goes into
learning a little day
by day;

The student of dao
reduces his assets by
dwindling or losing a
bit each day.

Learning consists in
adding daily to one's
stock, and the
practice of dao
consists in loose
dwindling day by
day. It could be
subtracting till one
has reached
inactivity. By steady
reductions [of certain
sorts] you reach
certain sorts of
laissez-faire.

The pursuit of
learning is to
increase day after
day. The pursuit of
Tao is to decrease
day after day.

It is to decrease and
further decrease until
one reaches the point
of taking no action.

not done.

Taking the world is
always done

by not making
anything of it.

For when something
is made of it,
that is not enough to
take the world.

Now there is nothing
that non-action
(letting things go)
cannot sort out. It is
through non-action
that one wins the
empire.

To act, in order to
win it, results in
failure.

on its own

A doer need not
intervene

Allow all things to
run their course

If you want to be
proficient

Make a fuss and
bother

And existence will be
insufficient

So decrease and
further decrease until
you reach the point
of taking no action.

[This is clowning.]
By artful inactivity
everything [bad] can
be set in motion.

He who conquers the
[inside] domain does
so [mostly] by doing
nothing. Those who
once won the
adherence of all who
live here, did so by
not interfering much.

Had they interfered,
they would never
have won this
adherence.

No action is
undertaken, And yet
nothing is left
undone. An empire is
often brought to
order by having no
activity.

If one (likes to)
undertake activity, he
is not qualified to
govern the empire.

Sages Have No Fixed Mind
Sages have no fixed mind;
they make the minds of the people their mind:
they improve the good,
and also improve those who are not good;
that virtue is good.
They make sure of the true,
and

The Sage has no definite will of his own, he accommodates himself to the will of the people.
He treats the good and the bad equally well, which is the true practice of goodness.
He trusts the sincere and insincere alike,

The seer doesn't own a thought
For thoughts do not reside within
Thoughts concern ten thousand things
And that's the way it's always been
The seer doesn't rush to judge
And treats all people well
Considers no one bad or good
Attracts but never does repel
The

The wise man makes no judgements of his own. He has no rigid and plump ideas alone. Maybe no certain, opinionated feelings.
He uses the heart of the people as his own inner side and heart. People's opinions and feeling are then as his own.
He says:
Good ones I declare good; and I [often] treat those who are good with goodness, as I approve of the good man.
I also treat those who are not so good with goodness.
I often approve of the [said] bad; he gets goodness.
So bad ones I also declare good. That's the goodness on how goodness can be attained [by demagoguery].
The honest ones I believe; and [some] liars I also believe;
I am honest to those who are honest, and I am also honest to those who are not [so] honest.

The sage has no fixed (personal) ideas. He regards the people's ideas as his own.
I treat those who are good with goodness. And I also treat those who are not good with goodness. Thus goodness is attained.
I am honest to those who are honest, And I am also honest to those who are not honest.

they make sure of the untrue too;
that virtue is sure.
The relation of sages to the world
is one of concern:
they cloud their minds for the world;
all people pour into their ears and eyes,
and sages render them innocent.

which is the true practice of trust.
In this mixed-up world, the Sage is without any emotion, and has the same feelings for all. All men fix their eyes and ears on him. He treats them like children, (Daoism kindness, slightly disdainful).

seer trusts things as they are
And takes all people at their word
Giving trust to everyone
Knows faithfulness will be returned
The seer turns your view around
So you can never be beguiled
And gives you back all that you lost
The vision of a little child

By such means great honesty, the faith of virtue, can be attained and the honest gets [closer to rueful] truthfulness.
In dealing with the world a wise man seems like one dazed with a felt fear, and while governing his [little] empire he has no subjective viewpoint.
So a wise man lives in the world in peace, and his bright mind forms a sound whole with that of his [dear] people.
Then they all lend their sense perceptions - eyes and ears - and he treats them all - infants as well. But sometimes again a wise man, dealings with some world, for the world's sake dulls his wits.
Where a hundred families all the time strain their eyes and ears, the wise man all-sees a people are brought into a fold of one heart. Next the wise man regards them as his own dear children.
At times the wise man sees and hears no more than an infant. [that's not much.]

Thus honesty is attained.
The sage, in the government of his empire, has no subjective viewpoint. His mind forms a harmonious whole with that of his people. The all lend their eyes and ears, And he treats them all as infants.

From Life into Death
Exiting life, we enter death.

The followers of life are three out of ten, the followers of death are three out of ten;

in the lives of the people,
the dying grounds on which they are agitated
are also three out of ten.

What is the reason?
Because of the seriousness
with which they take life as

Men go forth into life, And return in death.

Out of ten men, three prolong their life (through cleanliness), three hasten their death (through their excesses), three compromise their life by the attachment they have to it, (And only one stays alive until his term, because he is not attached to it).

He who is not attached to his life,

Between the time when they are born
And the time that they will die

Three in ten will follow life

Three others only will deny

Three others are so casual

They live as though they're passing through

But one remains who clearly sees

There's not a single thing

He who aims at life could achieve his death. Out of living, death pops up. Who comes to life can go to death.

If three out of ten are life companions, then the same number are death companions as well. As such the latter are labelled death-spots: some take life, through activity, to death.

How is it?

Its much due to men's intensive striving after life; in part the intense activity of multiplying life. Some do feed life too grossly.

It's said that he who is a good preserver of his life can meet no tigers or wild buffaloes on land.

Man comes in to life and goes out to death.

Three out of ten are companions of life. Three out of ten are companions of death. And three out of ten in their lives lead from activity to death. And for what reason? Because of man's intensive striving after life.

I have heard that one who is a good preserver of

life.

It has been said that those who maintain life well do not meet rhinos or tigers on land and do not arm themselves in war.

There is no way for rhinos to gore them; there is no way for tigers to claw them; there is no way for weapons to get at them.

Why? Because they have no dying ground.

does not turn aside to avoid an encounter with a rhinoceros or a tiger; he throws himself into the fray without armour or weapons;

And he comes to no harm because he is proof against the rhinoceros horn, the tiger's claws, And weapons of combat. Why is this? ... Because, exteriorized through his indifference, death cannot take a hold on him.

to do

Can you be like the one who sees

The world emerging on its own?

What's needed for each moment

Arises from the great unknown

This one doesn't have a fear

Of weaponry or wild beast

These enemies can't harm the one

Whose separate self is long deceased

Such a one could have a true hold on life,

If so, in battle or fighting he should hardly try to escape from weapons. He should neither get very much touched nor vulnerable to weapons in battle. [Cf. dont be there]

The wild buffalo cannot butt its powerless horns against him,

The tiger cannot fasten its then useless claws in him and tear him apart,

And much absent weapons of war should find no place to enter - cannot thrust their blades into him. [The absent part is always to blame. Demagogy]

And why? (Demagogy, thats why]

his life will not meet tigers or wild buffaloes, And in fighting will not try to escape from weapons of war.

The wild buffalo cannot butt its horns against him, The tiger cannot fasten its claws in him, And weapons of war cannot thrust their blades into him. And for what reason? Because in him there is no room for death.

They rear them and develop them. They give them security and give them peace. They nurture them and protect them.

(Tao) produces them but does not take possession of them. It acts, but does not rely on its own ability. It leads them but does not master them. This is called profound and secret virtue.

The World Has a Beginning
The world has a beginning
that is the mother of the world.
Once you've found the mother,
thereby you know the child.
Once you know the child,
you return to keep the mother,
not perishing though the body die.
Close your eyes, shut your doors,
and you do

That which was, before the beginning of the world, became the mother of the world.
He who has reached knowledge of the mother (matter, the body), knows through that her son (the vital spirit which is enclosed in it). He who knows the son (his vital spirit) And conserves the mother (his body), will reach the end of his days without accident.
If he keeps his mouth and nostril closed (to prevent evaporation of the vital spirit),

All things emerge from nullity
The only derivation
Of everything that manifests
The source of all creation
Stay in touch with origin
There's nothing that you need deny
Seeing your totality
You will not fear to die
Do not be in haste to speak

There was a [bang] start of the universe, call it the mother of the world.
Who has found that mother dao, also understands [some of] her sons (things) by it. From the mother, we can know her sons.
Having understood some sons, yet keep to the inner, subtle mother.
Who has known the sons will hold to the mother, for one's whole life can be protected from danger by it. [So they say.]
Shut down life's various openings. Close its doors, and till the end your strength may remain. Next, your whole life can seem without toil.
On the other hand; open the mouth busy about affairs, and to the end

There was a beginning of the universe Which may be called the Mother of the Universe.
He who has found the mother (Tao) And thereby understands her sons (things), And having understood the sons, Still keeps to its mother, Will be free from danger throughout his lifetime.
Close the mouth. Shut the doors (of cunning and desires).

not toil all your life.
Open your eyes, carry out your affairs, and you are not saved all your life.
Seeing the small is called clarity;
keeping flexible is called strength.
Using the shining radiance,
you return again to the light,
not leaving anything to harm yourself.
This is called entering the eternal.

he will reach the end of his days without having suffered decadence.
Whereas, if he talks a lot and causes himself much worry, he will use up and shorten his life.
Restricting one's considerations to small things, And one's cares to affairs of little importance, makes the mind clear and the body strong.
Concentrating one's intellectual rays in one's intelligence, And not letting mental applications harm one's body, is to protect (the mind) And make for long (life).

And always guard the senses
You will find your heart at peace
And in the place where all commences
See the subtle and the clear
It is the empty source of light
There is no danger in this place
That is forever in plain sight

of life there will be no help or salvation coming to you [from the outer realm].
Good sight implies seeing what's very small. Seeing what's small is called [Zen] enlightenment.
Who stays by some good conduct is strong. So use the light and return to clear sight through the bright light of the subtle, shining inner realm [debated in Buddhism]
By this art, never cause yourself future distress, [but see well in advance by the inner realm's sight and bright light; or just psyche such things out,] thereby preserved from most harm.
This is called resorting to the always-so, or practising the eternal.
That act is also called to steal the absolute.

And to the end of life there will be (peace) without toil.
Open the mouth. Meddle with affairs. And to the end of life there will be no salvation.
Seeing what is small is called enlightenment. Keeping to weakness is called strength.
Use the light. Revert to enlightenment. And thereby avoid danger to one's life - This is called practicing the eternal.

Causing One Flashes
Causing one flashes
of knowledge
to travel the Great
Way, only its
application demands
care.
The Great Way is
quite even,
yet people prefer
byways.
When courts are
extremely fastidious,
the fields are
seriously

He who has little
wisdom, should
conform himself to
the great Principle.
He should take care
to avoid any irksome
boasting.
But to this wide road
many prefer the
narrow sidetracks.
(Few men walk along
the way of obscure
disinterestedness.
They prefer the
narrow tracks of their
vanity, their own
advantage. This is
how the princes of
these times act).
When the palaces are
too well kept

This way is wide and
easy
Yet people love to
stray
They love to take the
sidetracks
And wander from the
way
When the few are
rich and wealthy
Living way above
their needs
The granaries are
empty
And the fields are
full

Once started on the great
[lax] highway, if I had
but little [Vossing]
knowledge I should, in
walking on a broad way,
fear getting off the road.
On the main path (dao), I
would avoid the
by-paths.
Some dao main path is
easy to walk [or drift]
on, but safe and easy.
All the same people are
fond, men love by-paths,
love even small
by-paths:
The by-path courts are
spick-and-span. And the
fields go untilled, nay,
exceedingly weedy.
They're content to let
their fields run to weed.
All
the while granaries stand
quite empty and some
exceedingly —

If I had but little
knowledge I should,
in walking on a broad
way, Fear getting off
the road.
Broad ways are
extremely even, But
people are fond of
bypaths.
The courts are
exceedingly
splendid, While the
fields are
exceedingly weedy,

neglected,
and the granaries are
very empty;
they wear colorful
clothing and carry
sharp swords,
eat and drink to their
fill
and possess more
than enough.
This is called the
vanity of thieves;
it is not the Way.

up, the fields go
uncultivated and the
granaries empty,
(because the farm
workers are
requisitioned for
forced labour).
Dressing
magnificently,
wearing a sharp
sword, stuffing
oneself with food and
drink, amassing
wealth to the extent
of not knowing what
to do with it (as do
the princes of these
times), is being like a
brigand (who
ostentatiously plays
with his loot). Such
conduct is opposed to
the Principle.

of weeds
When rulers spend
on weapons
And implements of
war
It's a never ending
circle
Of ever wanting
more
When the rich have
all abundance
What remains must
surely dwindle
Having more than
you can use
Is thievery and fraud
and swindle

empty.
They have elegant, in
clothes and gown to
wear, some furnished
with patterns and
embroideries,
Some carry sharp
weapons, glut
themselves with drink
and
foods enjoyed beyond
limit,
And wealth and
treasures are
accumulated in excess,
owning far more than
they can handle and use.
This is to [molest] the
world towards
brigandage, it's robbery
as extravagance. In the
end they're splitting with
wealth and possessions.
Wealth splits, tends to.

And the granaries are
exceedingly empty.
Elegant clothes are
worn, Sharp weapons
are carried, Food and
drinks are enjoyed
beyond limit, And
wealth and treasures
are accumulated in
excess. This is
robbery and
extravagance. This is
indeed not Tao (the
Way).

Chapter 54
Wing-Tsit Chan

When one cultivates virtue in his country, it becomes abundant virtue. When one cultivates virtue in the world, it becomes universal.

Therefore the person should be viewed as a person. The family should be viewed as a family. The community should be viewed as a community. The country should be viewed as a country. And the world should be viewed as the world.

How do I know this to be the case in the world? Through this.

The Richness of
Subliminal Virtue

The richness of
subliminal virtue

is comparable to an
infant:

poisonous creatures
do not sting it,

wild beasts do not
claw it,

predatory birds do not
grab it.

Its tendons are
flexible,

yet its grip is firm.

Even while it knows
not of the mating of
male and female,

its genitals get
aroused;

this

He who holds
himself in perfect
Virtue (without lust
or anger) is like the
new-born child
whom the scorpion
does not bite, the
tiger does not devour,
the vulture does not
seize, whom all
respect. A child's
bones are weak, its
tendons are feeble,
but it grasps objects
strongly (just as its
soul and body are
held together by
force).

He has not yet any
notion of the act of
generation, And, in
consequence, keeps
his seminal virtue —

One who sees full
emptiness

Is like a child just
born

With muscles weak
and bones so soft

Yet with a grip that's
strong

The newborn hasn't
been fulfilled

Its nature is pure
vacancy

Nullity and
nothingness

And potent
spontaneity

It can scream

He who has a lot of mystic
might also should be strong
in secret able influence-might
- quite free from getting
harmed, at times like a tender
child: full of childlike virtue
at its best.

Then no poisonous insects
should sting him. Fierce
beasts should not seize him
and wild beasts hardly attack
him, clawing birds of prey
should not pounce on and
harass him.

The bones of this dear little
one are soft and tender, his
sinews tender, but his grip is
quite firm.

He hardly yet knows about
the union of male and female,
yet his organs are fully
formed and well, at times
aroused. This means that his
essence is at its height there
and then, or means that the
vital force is at its height. [It
could be both.]

Such a one can cry all day
without getting hoarse if his
[libido as natural balance] is
whole and healthy [for it].

He who possesses
virtue in abundance
May be compared to
an infant. Poisonous
insects will not sting
him. Fierce beasts
will not seize him.
Birds of prey will not
strike him. His bones
are weak, his sinews
tender, but his grasp
is firm.

He does not yet know
the union of male and
female, But his organ
is aroused, This
means that his
essence is at its
height.

He may cry all day
without becoming
hoarse, This means
that his (natural)
harmony is perfect.

is the epitome of
vitality.

It can cry all day
without choking or
getting hoarse;

this is the epitome of
harmony.

Knowing harmony is
called constancy,

knowing constancy is
called clarity;

enhancing life is
called propitious,

the mind mastering
energy is called
strong.

When beings climax
in power, they wane;

this is called being
unguided.

The unguided die
early.

intact.

He cries softly all
day long without
becoming hoarse, so
perfect is his peace.
Peace makes for
durability; he who
understands this is
enlightened.

Whereas any violent
excitement, above all
lust and anger, wears
one out.

From this it follows
that virility (which
man abuses) is
succeeded by
decrepitude. Intense
life is contrary to the
Principle, And in
consequence
prematurely mortal.

and cry all day

And yet it never does
get hoarse

It only does what
naturally

Emerges from the
inner source

To see this inner
nature

Is seeing in a way
that's bold

Into the only place
there is

That cannot possibly
grow old

eternal.

Now, to know eternity full
well can be a discerning
matter. To know bland
harmony likewise implies to
be in eternity, or if missed, it
is to understand some
[principle of] always-so by
some degree of mental
illumination. But to be well
in accord with the eternal
means to be free as a bird.

To fill life to the brim is to
invite ugly portents, bad
omens. To force the growth
of life likewise spells ills.
Some ready at hand or to
come later on, maybe. Now,
if the heart makes calls upon
the life-breath, laziness or
[yogic] rigidity can follow
suit.

After things reach their
prime, they begin to grow
old, Whatever has a time of
vigour also has a time of
decay. Certain things age
after reaching their prime.

To know harmony
means to be in accord
with the eternal. To
be in accord with the
eternal means to be
enlightened.

To force the growth
of life means ill
omen. For the mind
to employ the vital
force without
restraint means
violence.

After all things reach
their prime, they
begin to grow old,
Which means being
contrary to Tao.
Whatever is contrary
to Tao will soon
perish.

Those Who Know
Do Not Say

Those who know do
not say;
those who say do not
know.

Close the senses,
shut the doors;
blunt the sharpness,
resolve the
complications;
harmonize the light,
assimilate to the
world.

He who knows (the
Principle), does not
speak.

He keeps his mouth
closed, controls his
breathing, blunts his
activity, rescues
himself from any
complication,
tempers his light,
And mingles with
people. This is
mysterious union
(with the Principle).

Those who know
don't like to say

Those who say don't
know

Close the mouth and
guard the senses

You'll see more than
what's on show

Untie tangles, dim
the glare

Dull the sharp

He who knows
doesn't speak
(artfully). He who
speaks hardly knows.

Fill your openings,
shut the doors,
Dull all nasty edges.
Untie all tangles.

Temper or soften all
glaring light.

Submerge its turmoil
as unified with the
world: Let all chaotic
hustle and bustle be
smoothed down.

This is the called the
mysterious [Vossing]
levelling for bland
unity or deep insider
identification.

He who knows does
not speak. He who
speaks does not
know.

Close the mouth.
Shut the doors. Blunt
the sharpness. Untie
the tangles. Soften
the light. Become
one with the dusty
world. This is called
the profound
identification.

Therefore it is
impossible either to
be intimate and close
to him or to be
distant and
indifferent to him.

This is called
mysterious sameness.

It cannot be made
familiar,
yet cannot be
estranged;
it cannot be profited,
yet cannot be
harméd;
it cannot be valued,
yet cannot be
demeaned.

Therefore it is
precious for the
world.

No one can attach
himself (by doing
favours) to such a
man, nor repulse him
(by treating him
badly). He is
indifferent to gain or
loss, exaltation or
humiliation. Being
thus, he is the most
noble in the world.

and join the dust

Abide in primal unity

And then do what
you must

You cannot hold it or
let go

It can't be blamed or
praised

In all-embracing
oneness

Be astonished and
amazed

who are said to have
achieved it.

Certain forms of loss
can hardly reach up
to this.

It can be hard to repel
and shoo such an
accomplished
god-being, as it's
impossible to be
distant and
indifferent to him.

He can't be raised,
can't be much
humbled, and
disgrace can hardly
affect him deep
inside.

It is impossible either
to benefit him or to
harm him. It is
impossible either to
honour him or
disgrace him. For this
reason he is
honoured by the
world.

Govern Nations by Normalcy

Use straightforwardness for civil government, use surprise for military operations; use noninvolvement to take the world.

How do I know this?

The more taboos there are in the world, the poorer the populace is; the more crafts the people have the more exotic things are produced; the more laws

One can govern with rectitude, one can wage war with competence, but it takes non-action to win and hold the empire. How do I know that this is so?

From what I am going to say:

The more rules there are, the less people enrich themselves. The more taxes there are, the less order there is.

The more ingenious inventions there are, the fewer serious and useful objects there are.

To truly lead with fairness

You must put aside control

Abandon imposition

Make spontaneity your goal

The more you try to run their lives

With rules and prohibition

The poorer people's lives become

The more they live in opposition

The more you deal with others

With cunning and with guile

The more that other people say

Our —

Kingdoms can only be governed if rules are kept; rule a kingdom by some normal standards and with utmost discretion.

Battles, on the other hand, can be won if rules are aptly broken. Operate the army and fight some battles by (unusual) tactics of surprise and attack.

Yet administer the kingdom by engaging in no activity. Win the world by doing next to nothing, for major adherence can only be won by letting well alone.

How do I know this will be so? By this:

The more prohibitions, ritual avoidances, and taboos there are, the poorer the people will end.

The more 'sharp weapons' there are, the more troubled and chaotic the state will be, and the more benighted

Govern the state with correctness. Operate the army with surprise tactics. Administer the empire by engaging in no activity. How do I know that this should be so?

Through this:

The more taboos and prohibitions there are in the world, The poorer the people will be. The more sharp weapons the people have, The more troubled the state will be.

The more cunning and skill a man possesses, The more vicious things will appear.

are promulgated, the greater the number of thieves. Therefore the sage says,

I contrive nothing, and the people are naturally civilized; I am fond of tranquillity, and the people are naturally upright.

I have nothing to do, and the people are naturally enriched; I have no desire, and the people are naturally simple.

The more detailed the penal code, the more thieves abound. Multiplication ruins everything.

Therefore the programme of the Sage is quite the contrary. Not acting, And the people amend themselves. Staying peaceful, And the people rectify themselves.

Doing nothing, And the people enrich themselves. Wishing for nothing, And the people come back to natural spontaneity.

lives are not worthwhile

The more you hoard your treasures

The more you're giving hope to thieves

The more you sharpen weapons

The more the country grieves

Do nothing and see all is done

And everyone is true

Drop the rules and people owe

Prosperity to you

Just let go of all desire

And people will return

To natural and simple ways

To life without concern

the whole land will grow.

The more cunning craftsmen there are, the more skills of technique, the more vicious things will appear: the more pernicious contrivances will be invented.

The more laws are promulgated, the more thieves and bandits there will be. So: The greater the number of statutes, the greater the number of thieves in the end.

So a wise man decreed:

So long as I "do nothing" the people get transformed of themselves.

So long as I love quietude, the people will of themselves go straight.

So long as I act only by proper inactivity the people will of themselves grow rich.

The more laws and orders are made prominent, The more thieves and robbers there will be.

Therefore the sage says: I take no action and the people of themselves are transformed. I love tranquillity and the people of themselves become correct.

I engage in no activity and the people of themselves become prosperous. I have no desires and the people of themselves become simple.

And the good again will become evil. The people have been deluded for a long time.

Therefore the sage is as pointed as a square but does not pierce. He is as acute as a knife but does not cut. He is as straight as an unbent line but does not extend. He is as bright as light but does not dazzle.

To Govern the Human and Serve the Divine

To govern the human and serve the divine, nothing compares to frugality.

Only frugality brings early recovery;

early recovery means buildup of power.

Build up virtue, and you master all.

When you master all, no one

The essential for co-operation with heaven in the government of men, is to moderate one's action.

This moderation should be the prime care.

To serve and care for others

With restraint and moderation

Stay centered in the here and now

And

In managing human affairs, there's no better rule than to be sparing, which is to forestall. You can't rule men nor serve heaven unless you have laid up a store; Be [simply artistic] frugal, there's nothing better for serving heaven and ruling people.

To forestall is to be prepared and strengthened; and by being frugal in such ways one may recover quickly. To recover quickly means to accumulate [intense moral] rather much. This "laying up a store" means quickly absorbing. And "quickly absorbing" in the end means doubling one's garnered "power". Double your garnered power and it acquires a strength that nothing can overcome. By the heavy accumulation of virtue one can overcome everything. Be prepared and strengthened to be always victorious: to have infinite capacity;

To rule people and to serve Heaven there is nothing better than to be frugal.

Only by being frugal can one recover quickly. To recover quickly means to accumulate virtue heavily. By the heavy accumulation of virtue one can overcome everything. If one can overcome everything, then he will acquire a capacity the limit of which is beyond anyone's knowledge.

knows your limit.

When no one knows your limit, you can maintain a nation.

When you maintain the matrix of a nation, you can last long.

This is called making the root deep and the basis firm, the Way of long life and eternal vision.

It procures perfect efficacy, which succeeds in everything, even the governing of the empire.

He who possesses this mother of the empire (wise moderation), will last a long time.

It is called the pivoting root, the solid trunk. It is the principle of perpetuity.

free of limitation

If you keep returning

To this your central root

You will possess forever

Awareness undilute

there's nothing it can't overcome, it knows no bounds, then he will acquire a capacity with limits well beyond anyone's knowledge.

One can next overcome nearly everything. And only what knows no bounds is huge enough to keep a whole kingdom in its grasp. If his capacity is beyond anyone's knowledge, he is fit to rule a kingdom. Who has infinite capacity is fit to rule, but only he who having the kingdom goes to the mother, can keep it long. He who possesses he mother (dao) of the state will last long. The mother (principle) of a ruling country can long endure.

When his capacity is beyond anyone's knowledge, he is fit to rule a state.

He who possesses the Mother (Tao) of the state will last long.

This means that the roots are deep and the stalks are firm, which is the way of long life and everlasting vision.

Governing a Large Nation Is like Cooking Small Fry

Governing a large nation is like cooking little fish.

When the world is ruled by the Way, the ghosts are powerless.

It is not that the ghosts

To govern a great state, one should act like someone cooking a very small fish (very delicately, otherwise they break up).

When a state is governed according to the Principle, phantoms do not appear there to harm the people, because the Sage who governs does not harm the

It's best to lead a large domain

As you would cook a little fish

Don't poke and prod or you are bound

To spoil the country and the dish

Just stay open and aware

And evil

Ruling a big kingdom is like frying a small fish.

They who by dao ruled all that's under heaven did not let an evil spirit within them display its powers. Such evil spirits did not display their supernatural powers; the spirits of wise men were hardly used to hurt other men. So when dao is employed to rule the kingdom, spiritual beings will lose their supernatural grip and cease to harm common people. And their supernatural power will far from harm people, and the wise man also will refrain from harming people.

Ruling a big country is like cooking a small fish.

If Tao is employed to rule the empire, Spiritual beings will lose their supernatural power.

Not that they lose their spiritual power, But their spiritual power can no longer harm people.

are powerless; their spirits do not harm the people.

Not only do the spirits not harm the people;

sages do not harm the people either.

Because the two do not harm each other, their virtues ultimately combine.

people.

Not that the spirits have no more powers, But their powers will not harm men./ Neither will they harm men, Nor will the Sage harm the people.

The merit of this double tranquility (on the part of the living and the dead) comes back, therefore, to the Sage.

cannot get a hold

Cannot find a home in you

Even evil's not that bold

At center you harm no one

And no one's able to harm you

This kind of reciprocity

Creates the world anew

When both don't do each other harm, virtue (power) flows towards them. If the sage's good spirit is nowhere mobilised to harm other men, he himself can be saved from [deterioration] harm.

And so, if evil spirits and supermen don't harm each other, each can be quite saved from harm.

Furthermore, some of their "tall abilities" could converge. If so, virtue can be accumulated in both for ulterior benefit or towards some common [soap opera] end.

Not only will their supernatural power not harm people, But the sage also will not harm people.

When both do not harm each other, Virtue will be accumulated in both for the benefit (of the people).

A Great Nation
Flows Downward

A great nation flows
downward

into intercourse with
the world.

The female of the
world

always prevails over
the male by stillness.

Because stillness is
considered lower,
by lowering itself to
a small nation

a great nation takes a
small nation;

by being lower than a
great nation

If a great state lowers
itself, like those holes
in which water
accumulates,
everyone will come
to it. It will belike the
universal female. In
her apparent
passivity and
inferiority, the
female is superior to
the male (for it is she
who gives birth).

On condition of
knowing how to
lower itself, a great

A great domain is
like the sea

Whose power comes
from lying low

And due to this
humility

Its greatness has to
grow

A small domain can
lie low too

A big kingdom can be
compared to the lower
part of a river, like the low
ground which all streams
flow down towards.

Here is a point towards
which all things under
heaven converge. Its part
must be that of the woman

who overcomes man by
simple quietude. By [such
as] quiescence she gets
underneath, and by
tranquillity she is down
under.

A big kingdom can take
over [a soul of] a small
one if it succeeds in
getting itself below the
small kingdom; If so it
absorbs some from the
small country, or wins
some adherence of the
small kingdom in the
open.

A big country may be
compared to the
lower part of a river.

It is the converging
point of the world; It
is the female of the
world. The female
always overcomes
the male by
tranquillity, And by
tranquillity she is
underneath.

A big state can take
over a small state if it
places itself below
the small state; And
the small state can
take over a big state
if

a small nation takes a
great nation.

So one takes by
lowering itself,
another takes by
being lower.

A great nation wants
no more

than to include and
nurture people;

a small nation wants
no more

than to admit and
serve people.

Both get what they
want,

so the great should be
below.

state will win over
lesser states,

which in their turn,
will lower
themselves, seeking
its protection.

For this to be
realized, only one
thing is needed, but it
is essential. It is that
the great state deigns
to lower itself before
the lesser ones. (if it
is proud and hard,
there is no hope).

Acknowledging its
low location

Surrender and
humility

Give rise to
exaltation

If you lie low you too
arise

To uppermost
position

For everyone's
attracted to

One who doesn't fear
submission

Therefore some place
themselves low so as to
take over or absorb
(others). Some are
(naturally) low and absorb
(others). Because small
kingdoms are by nature in
this way underneath large
kingdoms, they
[sometimes] win the
adherence of large
kingdoms [or end].

What a big kingdom is
after is but to annex and
herd others. So what large
countries really need is a
lot of inhabitants. What
small countries need is
some place where their
surplus inhabitants can go
and get employment.

What they want can be
little more than to join, be
somewhat sheltered and
perhaps serve for it all.

Both can have what they
want; I say the large
kingdom must "get
underneath".

it places itself below
the big state.

Thus some, by
placing themselves
below, take over
(others), And some,
by being (naturally)
low, take over (other
states).

After all, what a big
state wants is but to
annex and herd
others, And what a
small state wants is
merely to join and
serve others.

Since both big and
small states get what
they want, The big
state should place
itself low.

The Way Is the Pivot
of All Things

The Way is the pivot
of all things:

the treasure of good
people,

the safeguard of
those who are not
good.

Fine words can be
sold,

honored acts can
oppress people;

why should people
who are not good
abandon them?

Therefore to establish
an emperor

and set

The Principle is the
palladium of all
beings. It is the
treasure of the good
(that by which they
are good), and the
salvation of the
wicked (that which
prevents them from
perishing).

It is to it that one
should be grateful
from affectionate
words, and the noble
conduct of good
people. It is with
regard to it, that the
wicked should not be
rejected.

I'm at the center and
the source

Of all ten thousand
things

Where I receive the
benefits

That pure awareness
brings

These benefits
belong to all

To good and bad the
same

For nature gives you
what you need

With no regard for
praise or blame

Words and deeds of
excellence

May bring you honor

Dao is thought up as the
mysterious secret of the
universe, it could be the
storehouse of "all
things", like the pivotal
worship centre in the
south-west corner in the
[old Chinese] house. It's
the good man's treasure
and the bad man's
support and resort.

Fine words can buy
honour, fine sayings can
be sold. Fine deeds can
win respect from others.
The best conduct is a
gift. Persons of noble,
grave demeanour are
accepted as gifts.

Even if a man is bad,
when has (dao) rejected
him? Why reject bad
people [the winners of
tomorrow if all goes
fine]? Even the bad let
slip no opportunity to
acquire gifts that fit them
well enough.

Tao is the storehouse
of all things. It is the
good man's treasure
and the bad man's
refuge.

Fine words can buy
honour, And fine
deeds can gain
respect from others.
Even if a man is bad,
when has (Tao)
rejected him?

Therefore on the
occasion of crowning
an emperor or
installing the three
ministers, Rather

up high officials,
one may have a great
jewel

and drive a team of
horses,

but that is not as
good

as advancing calmly
on this Way.

Why did the ancients
value this Way?

By it one can attain
without long seeking
and escape from the
faults one has;

therefore it is valued
by the world.

Not so that they
should become
complacent with their
sceptre and their
ancient four-horsed
chariot; but in order
that they should
meditate on the
Principle (advancing
themselves in their
knowledge, and in the
development of
others).

Why did the ancients
make so much of the
Principle? is it not
because it is the
source of all good and
the remedy for all
evil? It is the most
noble thing in the
world.

and acclaim

But nature values
each alike

And is indifferent to
fame

When new leaders
are installed

Don't send gifts or
lofty praise

Stay centered in the
unity

Provided by the
inward gaze

Why should you
esteem the void?

It does away with
imperfection

Those who seek are
bound to find

It disappears on close
inspection

Therefore on the
crowning of an emperor
and appointing his three
ministers of the state,
rather than send a disc
of jade and teams of four
horses, sit down and
deliver this dao. It can be
done without moving
from one's seat.

What did the old ones
say of this dao, how did
they prize it? Why did
they treasure such dao?

Did they not say of those
that have it "Pursuing,
they shall catch;
pursued, they shall
escape?" Or, "Search for
the guilty ones and
pardon them?" Or,
"Those who seek shall
have it, those who sin
shall be freed"?

They thought [common]
dao to be the most
precious, the treasure of
the world.

than present four
large pieces of jade
preceded by teams of
four horses, It is
better to kneel and
offer this Tao.

Why did the ancients
highly value this
Tao? Did they not
say, "Those who seek
shall have it and
those who sin shall
be freed"? For this
reason it is valued by
the world.

Do Nondoing
Do nondoing,
strive for nonstriving,
savor the flavorless,
regard the small as
important,
make much of little,
repay enmity with
virtue;
plan for difficulty
when it is still easy,
do the great while it
is still small.
The most difficult
things in the world
must be done while
they are easy;
the greatest things in

To act without
acting; to be busy
without being busy;
to taste without
tasting;
to look equally on the
great, the small, the
many and the few; to
be indifferent to
thanks and
reproaches; this is
how the Sage acts.
He only sets about
difficult
complications
through their easiest
details, and only
applies himself to

Begin with the easy
And do without
doing
There isn't a thing
That you should be
pursuing
Begin with the
simple
There's no need
attacking
Your greatness will
lie
In all that you're
lacking
Tackle problems

Succeed in the magician's
wu-wei: Accomplish
seemingly do-nothing.
Attend seemingly to
no-affairs. And do
completely without ado.
What runs, acts without
action, does without doing,
So let's taste without tasting.
Taste the flavourless. Taste
the flavourless without
tasting. Find flavourless
flavour.
Whether it's big or small,
many or few, requite hatred
with virtue.
Dao can make the small great
and the few many, can
requite injuries with some
decent deeds. But prepare for
the hard while it's still easy.
Deal with it while it's still
easy. Deal with the great or
big while it's still small.

Act without action.
Do without ado.
Taste without tasting.
Whether it is big or
small, many or few,
repay hatred with
virtue.
Prepare for the
difficult while it is
still easy. Deal with
the big while it is still
small.
Difficult
undertakings have
always started with
what is easy.

the world
must be done while
they are small.
Because of this sages
never do great things;
that is why they can
fulfill their greatness.
If you agree too
easily, you'll be little
trusted;
if you take it easy a
lot, you'll have a lot
of problems.
Therefore it is
through difficulty
that sages end up
without problems.

great problems in
their weak
beginnings.
The Sage never
undertakes anything
great, and that is why
he makes great
things.
He who promises
much, cannot keep
his word; he who
embarrasses himself
with too many things,
even easy things,
never succeeds in
anything.
The Sage keeps clear
of difficulty,
therefore he never
has any difficulties.

when they're small
And still subject to
solution
The largest problem
is resolved
By simple deeds of
diminution
Can you center every
day
And see all the seers
see
Empty here and
brimming there
A marvelous
asymmetry?

Everything great must be
dealt with while it's still
small.
Therefore the wise man never
has to deal with the great; and
so gets greatness. He never
strives for the great, by this
the great is had.
So great undertakings shall
start with what's small.
But again "Who makes rash
promises surely lacks. Who
lightly makes a promise, can
find it too hard to keep his
faith. And light assent
inspires little confidence.
Who takes things very easily
is surely in for dealing with
more difficulty in the end. So
"many easies" means many a
hard. In other words, who
makes light of many things
should find many difficulties.
From all this even the wise
man regards things as hard,
but he also knows how to
make the easy difficult. For
that reason he very seldom
meets with difficulties.
[Uha.]

And great
undertakings have
always started with
what is small.
Therefore the sage
never strives for the
great, And thereby
the great is achieved.
He who makes rash
promises surely lacks
faith. He who takes
things too easily will
surely encounter
much difficulty.
For this reason even
the sage regards
things as difficult.
And therefore he
encounters no
difficulty.

For this reason the sage takes no action and therefore does not fail. He grasps nothing and therefore does not lose anything;

A sane man is sane in knowing what things he can spare, In not wishing what most people wish, In not reaching for things that seem rare.

Therefore the sage desires to have no desire, He does not value rare treasures. He learns to be unlearned, and returns to what the multitude has missed (Tao). Thus he supports all things in their natural state but does not take any action.

Good Practitioners of the Way in Ancient Times

In ancient times, good practitioners of the Way

did not use it to enlighten the people, but to make them unsophisticated.

When people are unruly,

it is because of their sophistication.

So to govern a country by cunning is to rob the country.

In antiquity, those who conformed themselves to the Principle did not seek to make the people clever, but aimed at keeping them simple.

When people are difficult to govern, it is because they know too much.

Those of old who found the way

Could see their inner core

They saw that it was hidden

And didn't bring it to the fore

When people think they know the truth

They

In old times those who practised a dao well, did hardly aim to enlighten people, but to make them ignorant and hold them that way. It seems that the more knowledge people have, the harder they are to rule. Maybe it's hard for people to live in peace due to very much knowledge.

So he who rules the state through knowledge is robber of the state; and who seek to rule by giving knowledge could be like [coming] bandits preying on the land. Maybe all who seek to rule by knowledge form the nation's curse, eventually.

In ancient times those who practiced Tao well Did not seek to enlighten people, but to make them ignorant.

People are difficult to govern because they have too much knowledge.

Not using cunning to govern a country is good fortune for the country.

To know these two is also a model.

Being always aware of the model is called hidden virtue.

Hidden virtue is deep, far-reaching, in contrast to ordinary people.

Only when it is thus does it reach great accord.

Those who claim to procure the good of a country by disseminating instruction, are wrong, and ruin the country.

This is the formula of mysterious action, of great profundity, of great bearing.

It is not to the taste of (the curious) but, thanks to it, everything turns out well, peacefully.

want all others to concur

But they are happy and content

When they remain unsure

Don't try to lead with cleverness

Prefer instead simplicity

It's obvious that truth must lie

In nothingness and clarity

Those who seek not to rule by knowledge, are the nation's blessing. To rule without giving knowledge could bring a stock of good fortune to the land. [And maybe not.]

One who knows these two things also (sets) the standard.

Always to know such an old standard is called to of the deep, secret calibre.

When such secret virtue becomes clear, outgoing, far-reaching, and lets things revert back to some guessed at source, all related things could return to some natural state. It could go all the way back to [brutal] concord and harmony.

Therefore he who rules the state through knowledge is a robber of the state; He who rules a state not through knowledge is a blessing to the state.

One who knows these two things also (knows) the standard. Always to know the standard is called profound and secret virtue.

Virtue becomes deep and far-reaching, And with it all things return to their original state. Then complete harmony will be reached.

Rivers and Seas Are
Lords of the Hundred
Valleys

The reason why
rivers and seas

Can be lords of the
hundred valleys

is that they lower
themselves to them
well;

therefore they can be
lords

of the hundred
valleys.

So when sages wish
to rise above people,

they lower
themselves to them
in their speech.

When

Why are the oceans
and rivers kings of all
the valleys?
(receiving all the
watercourses in
tribute). Because
they are benevolently
the inferiors of all the
valleys (with regard
to levels). That is
why all the water
flows towards them.

Following this
example, the Sage
who wishes to
become superior to
the common people
should speak in
words beneath
himself (speak very
humbly of himself).

The sea is large and
mighty

Because it lies below

The streams and
rivers of the world

Thus capturing their
flow

If you want to have
your fill

Then you must see
that you are hollow

If you want to lead
the way

Then you must be
prepared to

How did the great
rivers and seas
become the kings of
the ravines? By being
experts at keeping
low.

Therefore to be above
the people you have to
speak as though you're
lower than the people
in some ways.

So to be ahead of the
people, you have to
follow them in your
own person. To be
foremost or guide
well, walk behind.

The wise man keeps
himself on top, and
the people hardly feels
his weight or get
crushed by it in time.

The great rivers and
seas are kings of all
mountains streams
Because they
skillfully stay below
them. That is why
they can be their
kings.

Therefore, in order to
be the superior of the
people, One must, in
the use of words,
place himself below
them.

they want to precede
people,

they go after them in
status.

So when sages rule,

people don't take it
gravely.

And when sages are
in the forefront,

people don't attack
them.

Therefore the world
happily backs them
and does not tire of
them.

Because they do not
contend,

no one in the world
can contend with
them.

If he wishes to
become the first, he
should put himself in
last place, (and
continue to do so,
after he has been
exalted).

He could then be
elevated to the
highest peak without
the people feeling
oppressed by him; he
could be the first
without the people
complaining about
him. The whole
empire would serve
him with joy, without
becoming weary of
him.

For, not being
opposed to anyone,
no one would be
opposed to him.

follow

When you lead you
are above

But no one feels put
down

And when you must
be out in front

Know that no one's
losing ground

When you see that
you're not built

For facing up or
confrontation

No one can contend
with you

Who are the ultimate
negation

least.

He can even walk in
front [as an example],
and people don't wish
him harm. [Let's hope
that.]

In this dynamic [guru]
way everything under
heaven will be glad to
be pushed by him and
will not find his
guidance irksome.
Then the people of the
world are glad, the
world rejoices and
praises him without
getting tired of it, in
order to uphold him
forever.

And in order to be
ahead of the people,
One must, in one's
own person, follow
them.

Therefore the sage
rejoices in praising
him without getting
tired of it.

It is precisely
because he does not
compete that the
world cannot
compete with him.

Everyone Says
Everyone in the world
says my Way is great,
but it seems
incomparable.
It is just because it is great
that it seems
incomparable:
when comparisons are
long established
it becomes trivialized.
I have three treasures
that I keep and hold:
one is mercy,
the second is frugality,
the third is not presuming
to be at the head of the
world.
By reason of mercy,
one can be brave.
By reason of

Everyone says the
Sage is noble, despite
his common air; an air
which he gives
himself because he is
noble (to hide his
nobility and not to
attract envy to
himself). Everyone
knows, on the
contrary, how much
those who pose as
nobles are men of
little worth.
The Sage prizes three
things and holds on to
them: charity,
simplicity, and
humility.
Being charitable, he
will be brave (within
just limits, without
cruelty).

On seeing inner
nothingness
You see it's great
beyond compare
Though many find it
curious
That you would even
care
I have three treasures
that I keep
The first is
friendliness
The second is to stay
behind
The third is wanting
less
For if you're

Every one says my dao is
greatly like folly. Just
because it's great, it looks like
folly. Great ways don't look
like the ordinary anyhow.
If it did not look like folly, it
could have turned small and
petty long ago! Then it would
have been small. As for
things that don't look foolish
to common men, there can be
no question about their
smallness.
I have three treasures. Guard
and keep them:
The first is a deep, deep
concern; call it mystic pity, if
you like.
The second is never too
much, which may mean
frugality.
And the third is refusal to be
ahead, foremost or first, for I
hardly dare to be ahead.
Deep, concerned love brings
guts [or fall].
Through not doing too much,
one has amplitude (of reserve
power):

All the world says
that my Tao is great
and does not seem to
resemble (the
ordinary). It is
precisely because it
is great that it does
not resemble (the
ordinary). If it did
resemble, it would
have been small for a
long time.
I have three
treasures. Guard and
keep them: The first
is deep love, The
second is frugality,
And the third is not
to dare to be ahead of
the world.
Because of deep
love, one is
courageous.

frugality,
one can be broad.
By not presuming
to be at the head of the
world,
one can make your
potential last.
Now if one were bold
but had no mercy,
if one were broad
but were not frugal,
if one went ahead
without deference,
one would die.
Use mercy in war,
and you win;
use it for defense,
and you're secure.
Those whom heaven is
going to save

Being simple, he will
be liberal (within just
limits, without waste).
Being humble, he will
govern men without
tyranny.
The men of today
have forgotten charity,
simplicity, and
humility. They prize
war, ostentation, and
ambition. This is like
wishing not to
succeed. It is like
wishing to perish.

friendly and you care
You can dare to do
what's needed
And if you always
stay behind
The lead will surely
be conceded
And if you're
satisfied with less
You have everything
to give
Keep these treasures
in your heart
Then you will truly
live

Who has spared, may then
give and seem generous.
Through not presuming to be
the first and best there is, one
can develop one's talent and
strength; let it mature to
dominate a world.
On the other hand,
to be bold by forsaking deep
love;
to be generous by forsaking
frugality-won reserves and
clever, artful restraint;
and to be ahead and rushing
in front by forsaking
following behind;
all this could prove fatal in
the end.
Ardent, loving concern can't
fight well without conquering
a lot. It shall help in the case
of attack, and likewise to be
firm in the case of defence.
When heaven is to save a
person, heaven will protect
him through deep love.
Heaven arms those it would
not see beaten, with all right
concern. [Let's hope that.]

Because of not
daring to be ahead of
the world, one
becomes the leader
of the world.
Now, to be
courageous by
forsaking deep love,
To be generous by
forsaking frugality,
And to be ahead of
the world by
forsaking following
behind - This is fatal.
For deep love helps
one to win in the case
of attack, And to be
firm in the case of
defense. When
Heaven is to save a
person, Heaven will
protect him through
deep love.

Good Warriors
Good warriors do not
arm,
good fighters don't
get mad,
good winners don't
contend,
good employers
serve

He who commands
should not think that
tactics, valour, and
effort give victory.
It is by putting
oneself at the service
of men that one
subdues them. That is
the correct
procedure.
It is sometimes
formulated as
follows: art of not
struggling (of
accommodating
oneself, of winning
be making oneself
everything to
everyone); of ability
to manage men; of
action conforming to
that of heaven.

Violence is not the
way
The greatest warriors
know
That treachery and
anger
Will not defeat the
foe
You

A skilful leader of
troops is never
oppressive with his
military strength. The
brave soldier is
hardly very violent;
The best fighter
doesn't become
visibly angry; he
hardly loses his
temper.
A skilful conqueror
doesn't compete with
people.

A skillful leader of
troops is not
oppressive with his
military strength. A
skilful fighter does
not become angry.
A skilful conqueror
does not compete
with people.

their workers.
This is called the
virtue
of noncontention;
this is called mating
with
the supremely natural
and pristine.

All these formulae
designate the same
thing. They show the
greatness of the
ancients.

only win if you don't
strive
And gain if you do
not oppose
This is the certain
victory
Simplicity bestows

The great conqueror
doesn't fight for
small issues alone.
The best user of men
acts as though he
were their inferior
and puts himself
below them by the
virtue of
not-competing.
This is called the
ability or capacity to
use men, or matching
heaven, or being
suited to the highest
found principle,
[maybe of old]

One who is skilful in
using men puts
himself below them.
This is called the
virtue of
non-competing. This
is called the strength
to use men. This is
called matching
Heaven, the highest
principle of old.

Sayings on Military Operations

There are sayings on the use of arms:

"Let us not be aggressors, but defend."

"Let us not advance an inch, but retreat a foot."

This is called carrying out no action, shaking

Rather be on the defensive than the offensive, rather retreat a step than advance an inch, are current principles of military art. It is worth more to yield than to triumph. Prevention (of war) through diplomacy is worth even more.

That is the meaning of certain abstruse formulae of military art, such as: advancing

In conflict just be cautious

And always on your guard

Rather than advance an inch

Instead retreat a yard

In this way you go along

And make your gain without

The strategists say:

"If I dare not be the guest, then let me be the host. When I dare not take the offensive, then I'll take the defensive. If you doubt your ability to advance, then retreat." Also: "When you doubt your ability to meet the enemy's attack, take the offensive yourself."

Much of this his implies to march without visible formations; its in part like rolling up the sleeve, and yet presenting no bare arm. Or it could be like stretching your arm without showing the sleeves.

Confront well, present no battle-front yourself. Refrain from charging in frontal attacks, and seem to be armed without weapons.

The strategists say: "I dare not take the offensive but I take the defensive; I dare not advance an inch but I retreat a foot."

This means: To march without formation, To stretch one's arm without showing it, To confront enemies

no arm, facing no enemy, wielding no weapon. No calamity is greater than underestimating opponents. If you underestimate opponents, you're close to losing your treasure. So when opposing armies clash, the compassionate are the ones who win.

without marching; defending oneself without moving an arm; status quo without fighting; holding on without weapons; and others. There is no worse curse than a war waged with little or no reason, (which is sought-after deliberately, and pushed beyond necessary limits). He who does that, exposes his own goods to loss, and causes great mourning.

advancing

You deal with the rival

As your position is enhancing

Remember that it's possible

Your rival just may yield

So don't advance on such a foe

Let differences be healed

[Let that come as a surprise.] Hold a thousand weapons without seeming to have them.

Now, great calamity comes from making light of an enemy. There's no greater catastrophe than if a foolishly underestimated enemy robs and destroys your most cherished treasures. It could even destroy your topmost treasure, your old, dear body. Refrain from having an enemy at the price of losing your body and life. Remember: He whose enemy presents no front, could lose his booty.

Therefore when armies meet, the kind-looking man of sorrows could win [by such as surprise tactics. But often it's the opposite that happens.] Who doesn't delight in warfare in the open, he wins. [And most often not?]

without seeming to meet them, To hold weapons without seeming to have them.

There is no greater disaster than to make light the enemy.

Therefore when armies are mobilized and issues joined, The man who is sorry over the fact will win.

My Sayings Are
Very Easy to
Recognize

My sayings are very
easy to recognize,
and very easy to
apply.

But no one in the
world can recognize
them,
and no one can apply
them.

Sayings have a

What I (Lao Zi) teach
is easy to understand
and to practice, and
yet the world neither
understands or
practices it.

My precepts and
procedures derive
from a superior
principle and
procedure, the
Principle and its
Virtue.

Embarrassingly
obvious

And always near at
hand

It is this nothingness
you see

But never understand
Though truth within

My words are very
easy to understand
and very easy to put
into practice. Yet no
one understands
them; no one puts
them into practice.

But some of my
teaching could have
nature as a source,
and also there's a
principle-ruled
ancestry in some of
my words.

Yes, [some of] my
deeds have a lord;

My doctrines are
easy to understand
and very easy to
practice, But none in
the world can
understand or
practice them.

My doctrines have a
source (Nature); my
deeds have a master
(Tao).

source,
events have a leader.

It Is only through
ignorance
that I am not known.

Those who know me
are rare;
those who emulate
me are noble.

This is why sages
dress plainly,
and conceal what is
precious.

The world does not
recognize the
Principle which
directs me, that is
why it does not know
me. Very few
understand me. That
makes my glory.

It befalls me to be
like the Sage who is
unrecognized from
amongst the common
people because of his
humble appearance,
even though his
interior is filled with
jewels.

is ageless

Very few will ever
see

My face is what I
give to you

The jewel within is
me

my deeds could have
[right] dao as
sovereign.

Most men don't
understand this,
they're unable to
understand me.

Few people
understand me, and
on this my real value
depends. I am highly
valued, for few
understand me.

The wise man wears
a coarse cloth on top
and carries jade
underneath his dress,
within his bosom.

It is because people
do not understand
this that they do not
understand me. Few
people know me, and
therefore I am highly
valued.

Therefore the sage
wears a coarse cloth
on top and carries
jade within his
bosom.

Knowing
Unconsciously

To know
unconsciously is
best.

To presume to know
what you don't is
sick.

Only by recognizing
the sickness of
sickness

is

Knowing all and
believing that one
knows nothing, is
true knowledge (of a
superior kind).
Knowing nothing
and believing that
one knows
everything, is the
common evil of
humans.

You cannot
understand the truth

Claim to know and
show you're ill

Just see that you are
missing

That truth is bare

To know that you do
not know is best.
Who knows that he
doesn't know is the
highest. To know
when one doesn't
know is best.

Who pretends to
know what he doesn't
know is sick-minded;
To think one knows
when one doesn't
know is a sort of
malady. Pretend to
know when you don't
know - that's a
disease.

To know that you do
not know is the best.
To pretend to know
when you do not
know is a disease.

it possible not to be
sick.

The sages' freedom
from ills

was from recognizing
the sickness of
sickness,

so they didn't suffer
from sickness.

Seeing this evil as an
evil, keeps one away
from it.

The Sage is exempt
from self-conceit,
because he dreads it.
This fear keeps him
from it.

and nil

Unknowing is the
final cure

When knowledge
takes its heavy toll

Pure presence is
totality

And absence makes
you whole

He who recognises
this disease as a
disease can also cure
himself of it [and
maybe not]. [One
may eventually get
free from a disease
by recognising it for
what it is.]

Who recognises
sick-mindedness as
sick-mindedness
can't be wholly
sick-minded, after
all.

The wise man is
hardly sick-minded if
he recognises sick
mind as sick and also
cures some diseases.
He's hardly a sick
mind.

Only when one
recognizes this
disease as a disease
can one be free from
the disease.

The sage is free from
the disease. Because
he recognizes this
disease to be disease,
he is free from it.

When the People Are
Not Awed by
Authority

When the people are
not awed by
authority,
then great authority
is attained.

Their homes are not
small to them,
their livelihood not
tiresome.

Just because they do

Those (who expose
themselves to danger
through curiosity,
love of gain, or
ambition) should be
afraid when they are
not afraid. For they
are lost.

Do not consider your
place of birth too
restricting, do not
become dissatisfied
with the condition in
which you were born.
(Stay what you are
and where you are.
The effort to seek for
better could perhaps
cause you to lose you
way).

When the sense of
wonder goes

Disaster is not far
behind

Don't intrude in
people's lives

And they won't think
you are

If the people hardly
fear what's dreadful,
something greatly
dreadful could
descend. If people
have no fear of force,
then great force
descends. So never
mind if people are
not intimidated by
your authority. Some
mightier authority
could deal with them
in the long run.

Neither despise their
dwellings nor narrow
the living space of
their dwellings. They
could cease to turn
away if you don't put
them in jail. Don't
dislike their
offspring, harass or
oppress their lives.

When the people do
not fear what is
dreadful, Then what
is greatly dreadful
will fall upon them.

Do not reduce the
living space of their
dwellings. Do no
oppress their lives.

not tire of it,
it is not tiresome to
them.

Therefore sages
know themselves
but do not see
themselves.

They take care of
themselves

but do not exalt
themselves.

So they take one
and leave the other.

One does not become
dissatisfied, if one
does not wish to
become so.
(Dissatisfaction is
always voluntary,
coming from
preparing one's
situation with
another, and having
preference for the
other).

The Sage knows his
worth but does not
show it, (he does not
feel the need to show
it off). He respects
himself but does not
try to be esteemed.
He discerns, adopting
this, and rejecting
that (after the light of
his wisdom).

unkind

The seer sees both
this and that

But doesn't ask for
praise

Finding this
immensity

With just a simple
inward gaze

Don't harass them,
and they could cease
to turn from you.
Drop heavy taxes,
and the people won't
be fed up. If you
don't persecute all,
you'll hardly be so
much disliked.
They're not
oppressed if you
refrain from gross
oppressive measures.

So the wise man
knows himself but
hardly shows off.
Knows his own
value, but doesn't
exalt himself

It is because you do
not oppress them that
they are not
oppressed.

Therefore the sage
knows himself but
does not show
himself. He loves
himself but does not
exalt himself.
Therefore he rejects
the one but accepts
the other.

Boldness in Daring
Means Killing

Boldness in daring
means killing;

boldness in not
daring means life.

These two may help
and may harm.

Who knows the
reason for what
heaven dislikes?

This is why even
sages

find

Active (warlike)
courage procures
death. Passive courage
(patience, endurance)
conserves life.

Therefore there are
two courages, one
harmful, the other
beneficial. (Patience
and forbearance are
always worth more
than incisive action,
even in government,
in politics). For does
heaven wish harm, or
not, to this or that
man, or nation? ...
And why? ... Who
knows?

The way is very easy

Its purposes prevail

When all is done in
silence

Intention cannot fail

Its

Who is brave in daring
can kill or get killed [on a
bus].

On the other hand, one
who is brave in not
daring, can survive or
give life. Either approach
can be profitable or
unprofitable, still one of
them is harmful.

Who is brave in
non-daring without ado
lets live. There can be
some advantage and some
disadvantage in each
approach -

Now, "Dao-heaven hates
the one it hates, hates
what it hates; and none
can know the reason
why." Who knows why
and what it dislikes?
Heaven dislikes certain
people; but the wise man
considers it a tricky
question.

He who is brave in
daring will be killed.
He who is brave in
not daring will live.

Of these two, one is
advantageous and
one is harmful. Who
knows why Heaven
dislikes what it
dislikes? Even the
sage considers it a
difficult question.

The Way of Heaven
does not compete,
and yet is skillfully
achieves victory.

it hard for them.

The Way of heaven

wins well without
contest,

responds well
without speech,

comes of itself
uncalled,

relaxed yet very
resourceful.

The net of heaven is
vast;

the holes are large
but don't let slip.

- Therefore the Sage
always acts as though
embarrasses,
(hesitating, making up
his mind with
difficulty before any
active intervention).

For the way of heaven
(its constant conduct),
is not to intervene
positively. It wins
without fighting. It
makes things obey
without giving orders.
It makes them come
without calling them.
It brings everything to
its conclusion whilst
having the appearance
of letting everything
drag.

The heavenly net
catches all. Its mesh is
wide, but no one
escapes it.

net is vast and over
all

With meshes large
and wide

Yet it loses nothing

Holds everything
inside

Yes, why heaven seems to
hate - even a wise man
regards it as a tricky
question.

Well, it's in the fixed dao
sets of heaven not to
strive in the open, but
none the less to conquer.
Not to compete, but all the
same win expertly. Be
good at conquest without
strife.

Dao hardly speaks, it
skillfully responds. It
comes without skilful
invitation, it can appear
without a call. It doesn't
seem anxious about things
and yet it shows up it
plans very well. It gets
able results without
obvious design, as from
hidden, laid, [broad] plans
and schemes. [Say little,
foster well laid schemes
and designs.]

It does not speak, and
yet it skillfully
responds to things. It
comes to you without
your invitation. It is
not anxious about
things and yet it
plans well.

Heaven's net is
indeed vast. Though
its meshes are wide,
it misses nothing.

If People Usually
Don't Fear Death

If people usually
don't fear death,
how can death be
used to scare them?

If people are made to
fear death,
and you can catch
and kill them
when they act

If the people do not
fear death, what is
the good of trying to
control them by the
threat of death?

If they fear death,
then only capture and
execute those who
cause disorder,
turning the others
away from doing
likewise.

You truly are what
isn't born

You need not be
afraid to die

Just live your life and
know that you

Will never lose the

When the people are
not afraid of death,
why threaten them
with death sentences?

Even supposing the
people are constantly
afraid of death and
we can seize and kill
those who are unruly
or vicious, who
would dare to slay
them? There's always
the master
executioner
(Heaven). To kill in
his stead is like
thrusting oneself into
he master-carpenter's
place and doing his
chipping for him.
"He who tries it is
lucky if he doesn't
cut his hand," they
say.

The people are not
afraid of death. Why,
then, threaten them
with death?

Suppose the people
are always afraid of
death and we can
seize those who are
vicious and kill them,
Who would dare to
do so?

oddly,
who would dare?

There are always
executioners.

And to kill in place
of an executioner
is taking the place of
a master carver.

Those who take the
place
of a master carver
rarely avoid cutting
their hands.

(The legalists who
are lavish with the
death penalty and
believe it will sort
everything out, are
therefore wrong).

The servant of death
(heaven), kills, (let
him do it. Let us not
do his work. He
alone is capable of
it). The man who
wants to kill may end
up like those who
play with the
carpenter's tools, and
often lose a finger in
their play.

inner eye

You can't control
what is to be

In using tools you
don't command

Unlike the master
carpenter

You're bound to cut
your hand

To undertake
executions for the
master executioner is
like hewing wood for
him. It rarely
happens you escape
injuring your own
hands. Now, often it
happens as well that
the executioner is
killed -

And to take the place
of the executioner is
in part like handling
the hatchet for the
master carpenter. He
who handles the
hatchet for the master
carpenter seldom
escapes injury to his
hands.

There is always the
master executioner
(Heaven) who kills.
To undertake
executions for the
master executioner is
like hewing wood for
the master carpenter.
Whoever undertakes
hewing wood for the
master carpenter
rarely escapes
injuring his own
hands.

People's Starvation

When people are starving,
it is because their governments take too much,
causing them to starve.

When people are hard to control,
it is because of the contrivances of their governments,
which make them

If the people are hungry, it is because the prince eats up excessive sums of money (which he extorts from them).

If the people are restive, it is because the prince does too much, (indisposes them by his innovations).

If the people expose themselves lightly to death (in hazardous enterprises), it is because he loves life too much, (love of well-being, of pleasure, of fame).

The people starve when taxes take

The bulk of what they earn

When leaders interfere too much

They get rebellion in return

The people

People are hungry because rulers eat too much income, too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve, but also because of bad interference from those above. Some turn hard to rule as their rulers do too many things. That's why they're hard to keep in order.

If so, the people are not very afraid of death, as they're anxious to make a living.

The people starve because the ruler eats too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve.

They are difficult to rule because their ruler does too many things. Therefore they are difficult to rule.

The people take death lightly because their ruler strives for life too vigorously.

hard to control.

When people slight death,
it is because of the earnestness
with which they seek life;
that makes them slight death.

Only those who do not contrive to live are wise in valuing life.

He who does nothing in order to live, is wiser than he who harms himself in order to live.

do not fear to die

If leaders rob them of their lives

But taking no more than you need

You see that everybody thrives

That's why they take death lightly in such cases.

So: Those who interfere not with their living that are wise in exalting life. Maybe he who seeks only little after life can excel in making life valuable. But all that have hearts set only little on life could be superior to those who set store by life.

Therefore they take death lightly. It is only those who do not seek after life that excel in making life valuable.

When People Are Born

When people are born they are supple, and when they die they are stiff.

When trees are born they are tender, and when they die they are brittle.

Stiffness is thus a companion of

When a man is born he is supple and weak (but full of life); he becomes strong and powerful, and then he dies.

It is the same for plants, delicate (herbaceous) at first, then becoming woody at the time of their death.

He who is strong and powerful

We're soft and supple when we're born

Hard and rigid when we die

Living plants are pliable

Deadwood is brittle and dry

This way

When man is born, he is tender and weak. In death he becomes stiff and hard.

All things, the grass as well as trees, are supple and soft while alive. When dead they become brittle and dried.

So hardness and stiffness very often accompany death, the soft and gentle could be companions of life.

The headstrong army will lose in battle.

When man is born, he is tender and weak. At death he is stiff and hard.

All things, the grass as well as the trees, are tender and supple while alive. When dead, they are withered and dried.

Therefore the stiff and the hard are companions of death.

death, flexibility a companion of life.

So when an army is strong, it does not prevail.

When a tree is strong, it is cut for use.

So the stiff and strong are below, the supple and yielding on top.

is marked for death; he who is weak and flexible is marked for life.

The great army will be defeated. The great tree will be cut down.

Everything that is strong and great is in a poorer condition. The advantage is always with the supple and the weak.

life befriends the weak

But death draws near the strong

The hard and stiff are bound to break

The supple bends and goes along

They say "the weapon that's too hard will be broken, the tree that has the hardest wood will be cut down". Yes, a hard tree will be cut down.

So the hard and mighty eventually should be cast down; and the soft and weak may be set on high.

The tender and the weak are companions of life.

Therefore, if the army is strong, it will not win. If a tree is stiff, it will break.

The strong and the great are inferior, while the tender and the weak are superior.

The Way of Heaven
The Way of heaven
is like drawing a
bow:
the high is lowered,
the low is raised;
excess is reduced,
need is fulfilled.

Heaven acts (with
regard to men) like the
archer who, bending
his bow, makes the
convexities straight
and the concavities
bulge, diminishing the
greater and
augmenting the lesser.
(Lowering the higher,
and raising the lower).
It takes away from
those who have
plenty, and adds to
those who have little.
Whereas men (bad
princes who bleed the
people) do quite the
opposite, taking away
from those who lack
(the people), in order
to add to those who
have in abundance
(their favourites) —

Nature's way of
doing
Is like the bending of
a bow
For pulling on a bow
you see
The low go high and
the high go low
Nature takes from
those who have
And gives to those
who

Heaven's way is like
the bending of a bow.
When a bow is bent
the top comes down
and the bottom-end
comes up.
So too could heaven
take away from those
who have too much,
and give to those that
have not enough.
Take away from
those that have too
much and give to
those that have not
enough.
But this is far from
man's way.

Heaven's Way is
indeed like the
bending of a bow.
When (the string) is
high, bring it down.
When it is low, raise
it up. When it is
excessive, reduce it.
When it is
insufficient,
supplement it.
The Way of Heaven
reduces whatever is
excessive and
supplements
whatever is
insufficient. The way
of man is different.

The Way of heaven
reduces excess and
fills need,
but the way of
humans is not so:
they strip the needy
to serve those who
have too much.

...
Any superfluity ought
to come back to the
empire (to the people),
but only he who
possesses the
Principle is capable of
that.
The Sage conforms
himself to the
Principle. He
influences without
attributing the result to
himself. He
accomplishes without
appropriating his work
to himself. He does
not claim the title of
the Sage, (but keeps
himself in voluntary
obscurity).

lack
When nature takes
from human beings
They fight to get it
back
But if you see you
have it all
You're not afraid to
give away
Expecting nothing in
return
It all comes back
with no delay

He takes away from
those that have not
enough to offer those
who already have too
much.
The man of dao can
fool enough and
spare, and next give
to the whole world.
So the wise man acts,
but doesn't possess,
accomplishes but
lays claim to no
credit.

It reduces the
insufficient to offer
to the excessive.
Who is able to have
excess to offer to the
world? Only the man
of Tao.
Therefore the sage
acts, but does not
rely on his own
ability. He
accomplishes his
task, but does not
claim credit for it. He
has no desire to
display his
excellence.

The Most Flexible
Thing in the World

Nothing in the world
is more flexible
and yielding than
water.

Yet when it attacks
the firm and the
strong,
none can withstand
it,
because they have no
way to change it.

So the flexible
overcome the
adamant,
the yielding

In this world there is
nothing more supple
and weak than water;
and yet no one,
however strong and
powerful he may be,
can resist its action
(corrosion, wear,
wave action); and no
being can do without
it (for drinking,
growth, etc.).

Is it clear enough that
weakness is worth
more than strength,
that suppleness can
overcome rigidity?

Water is so very soft
It overcomes because
it yields

By wearing down the
hardest rock

It shows what power
weakness wields

The weak can
overcome the strong

The soft can
overcome

There's hardly
anything more
yielding than [gas,
air, and] water, but
almost none is better
in attacking the
resistant and hard,

There are few
substitutes for it.

Thus the yielding
may conquer the
resistant and the soft
the hard. This was
utilised by none I
knew.

Wise sayings,

There is nothing
softer and weaker
than water, And yet
there is nothing
better for attacking
hard and strong
things. For this
reason there is no
substitute for it.

All the world knows
that the weak
overcomes the strong
and the soft
overcomes the hard.

overcome the
forceful.

Everyone knows this,
but no one can do it.

This is why sages say
those who can take
on the disgrace of
nations
are leaders of lands;
those who can take
on the misfortune of
nations
are rulers of the
world.

True sayings seem
paradoxical.

- Everyone agrees
with this; but no one
acts according to it.

The Sages have said:
"He who rejects
neither moral filth
nor political evil is
capable of becoming
the chief of a
territory or the
sovereign of the
empire." (He who is
supple enough to
accommodate
himself to all that;
and not a rigid and
systematic person).
These words are
quite true, even
though they offend
many.

the hard

Everybody knows it's
true

So hold the low in
high regard

The seer sees
serenity

Where others see
affliction

The seer sees the
inner truth

Where others only
see a fiction

"Only he who has
accepted the dirt of a
country can be lord
of its soil-shrines:
can become
heaven-accepted
there. Who bears
evils of the country
can become a king.
Who takes into
himself the calumny
of the world serves to
preserve the state."

Straight words seem
crooked.

But none can practice
it.

Therefore the sage
says: He who suffers
disgrace for his
country Is called the
lord of the land. He
who takes upon
himself the country's
misfortunes Becomes
the king of the
empire. Straight
words seem to be
their opposite.

Harmonize Bitter
Enemies

When you harmonize
bitter enemies,
yet resentment is sure
to linger,
how can this be
called good?
Therefore sages keep
their faith
and do

When the principle
of a dispute has been
settled (some
accessory
grievances) always
remain, and things do
not return to the state
they were in before,
(bruises remain).
(Therefore the Sage
never questions it,
despite his right).
Keeping his half of
the agreement, he
does not exact the
execution (of what is
written).
He who knows how
to conduct himself
after the Virtue of the
Principle, lets his
written agreements
sleep.

There's little good in
making peace
If resentment lingers
You'll never see an
end to blame
If everyone is
pointing fingers
It's

To allay the main
discontent, but in a
way that begets
further discontents,
can hardly be top
successful. And to
patch up great hatred
is sure to leave some
hatred behind; how
can this be regarded
as satisfactory?
So the wise man
keeps the obligation
of a contract
and refrains from
blaming the other
party.

To patch up great
hatred is surely to
leave some hatred
behind. How can this
be regarded as good?
Therefore the sage
keeps the left-hand
portion (obligation)
of a contract And
does not

not pressure others.
So the virtuous see to
their promises,
while the virtueless
look after precedents.
The Way of heaven
is impersonal;
it is always with
good people.

He who does not
know how to conduct
himself thus, exacts
his due.
Heaven is impartial.
(If it were capable of
some partiality), it
would give
advantage to good
people, (those who
act as in C. It would
overwhelm them,
because they ask for
nothing).

better to be pointing
At the peaceful and
creative place
Where you see
naught but emptiness
And others say they
see your face

He stays where he is
and does not go
round making claims
on people.
Therefore good
people attend to their
obligations, while
those without virtue
attend to other
people's mistakes.
The way of heaven is
impartial. It's always
with the good man,
without distinction of
persons, to keep the
good firmly
supplied."

blame the other
party.
Virtuous people
attend to their
left-hand portions,
While those without
virtue attend to other
people's mistakes.
"The Way of Heaven
has not favourites. It
is always with the
good man."

A Small State Has Few People
A small state has few people.
It has the people keep arms
but not use them.
It has them regard death gravely
and not go on distant campaigns.
Even if they have vehicles,
they have nowhere to drive them.
Even if they have weapons,
they have nowhere to

If I were king of a little state, of a little people, I would take care to use (put in charge) the few dozen capable men that this state would contain.
I would prevent my subjects from traveling, by making them fear possible accidental death so much that they would not dare climb into a boat or carriage. I would prohibit all use of weapons.
As for writing and calculating, I would oblige them to go back to knotted cords.

If a land is small and the people few
And the rulers recognize what's needed
The simple ways of courtesy
Are happily and gladly heeded
For people need so little
To live their lives aright

Let there be a small country with few people.
Let there be ten times and a hundred times as many utensils and let them not be used.
Let there be contrivances requiring ten times, a hundred times less labour; they should not use them.
Let the people value their lives highly and not travel far. Bring it about that the people are quite ready to lay down their lives at times to defend their homes rather than emigrate.
As for ships and carriages, let there be none to ride.
There can still be weapons, but no one to drill

Let there be a small country with few people. Let there be ten times and a hundred times as many utensils. But let them not be used. Let the people value their lives highly and not migrate far.
Even if there are ships and carriages, none will ride in them. Even if there are arrows and weapons, none will display them.
Let the people again knot cords and use them (in place of writing).

use them.
It has the people go back to simple techniques,
relish their food,
like their clothes,
be comfortable in their ways,
and enjoy their work.
Neighboring states may be so close
they can hear each other's dogs and roosters,
but they make it so that the people
have never gone back and forth.

Then they would find their food tasty, their clothes fine, their houses peaceful, and their manners and customs agreeable.
(I would prevent curiosity and communication to the point where) my subjects would hear the noise of the cocks and dogs of the neighbouring state, but die from old age without having crossed the border and had relationships with the people there.

Are food and home and clothing
Not enough for pure delight?
Though nearby lands are close enough
To hear their roosters crow
The people will be so content
That not a one will want to go

seriously with them and none to display them often.
People should have no use for any form of writing save knotted ropes: Let the people again knot cords for reckoning.
Let them be very pleased with their food, beautify their clothing, be content with their homes, take pleasure in rustic tasks, and delight in such customs [just like Negroes].
The neighbouring place can be overlooked, can be so near that one may hear the cocks crowing in it, the dogs barking; but the people would grow old and die without ever having been there.
and never outside their country.

Let them relish their food, beautify their clothing, be content with their homes, and delight in their customs.
Though neighbouring communities overlook one another and the crowing of cocks and the barking of dogs can be heard, Yet the people there may grow old and die without ever visiting one another.

True Words Are Not Beautiful

True words are not beautiful,
beautiful words are not true.

The good are not argumentative,
the argumentative are not good.

Knowers do not generalize,
generalists do not know.

(I have finished. Perhaps you may find my discourse lacks something, is not very subtle, and is scarcely wise). This is because native frankness does not dress itself up, natural directness avoids quibbling, common sense can dispense with artificial erudition.

The Sage does not hoard, but gives.

Truth need not be eloquent

And eloquence may not be true

There is no need to argue

When truth is shining through

Those who see may not be learned

The learned may not see

To see you merely need to look

In pure simplicity

The seer

True words hardly sound fine. Nice words are far from always true.

A good man seldom proves by argument; he hardly argues. He who argues or proves by argument is hardly so good (as non-argumentative good men). Who argues [blatantly] is hardly (ever) a good man.

[All this is "Lao" arguing, debating or clowning.]

Brilliant wisdom is different from sordid learning. Much bookish learning can mean too little wisdom.

True words are not beautiful; Beautiful words are not true.

A good man does not argue; He who argues is not a good man.

A wise man has no extensive knowledge; He who has extensive knowledge is not a wise man.

The sage does not accumulate for himself.

Sages do not accumulate anything but give everything to others,
having more the more they give.

The Way of heaven helps and does not harm.

The Way for humans is to act without contention.

The more he does for men, the more he can do; the more he gives them, the more he has.

Heaven does good to all, doing no evil to anyone. The Sage imitates it, acting for the good of all, and opposing himself to no one.

doesn't have to hoard

And does not fear to lose

The more you give, the more you have

So why should you refuse?

Why not give it all away?

For emptiness brings benefit

And as the seers always say

The more you give, the more you get

Who has extensive knowledge is hardly a wise man.

The wise man has no need to hoard for himself. He lives for other people, seemingly, and grows richer himself if the more he uses for others, the more he has for himself - He gives to other people to get greater abundance.

Heaven's way is to sharpen and bless, all free from harm of cutting,

And the wise man's way is to act and accomplish without contending or striving.

The more he uses for others, the more he possesses of his own.

The Way of Heaven is to benefit others and not to injure. The Way of the sage is to act but not to compete.